

Aparna's dress smelt
fresh all day long*

Comfort



*Tested under lab conditions on select fabrics



SCO DEFENCE MEET
Rajnath calls for unity to eliminate terrorism
NEWS » PAGE 10



'DIGITAL ARREST LINKS'
Up to 9,400 accounts banned, says WhatsApp
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UNIVERSITY HIT
Pakistani strikes kill seven in Afghanistan
WORLD » PAGE 14



UNFORTUNATE DEVIATION
A recusal test that the Delhi High Court failed
Judicial principles tested in the liquor policy case
EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



THE BIG ROAR
Gritty Royals snap Kings' winning run
SPORT » PAGE 15

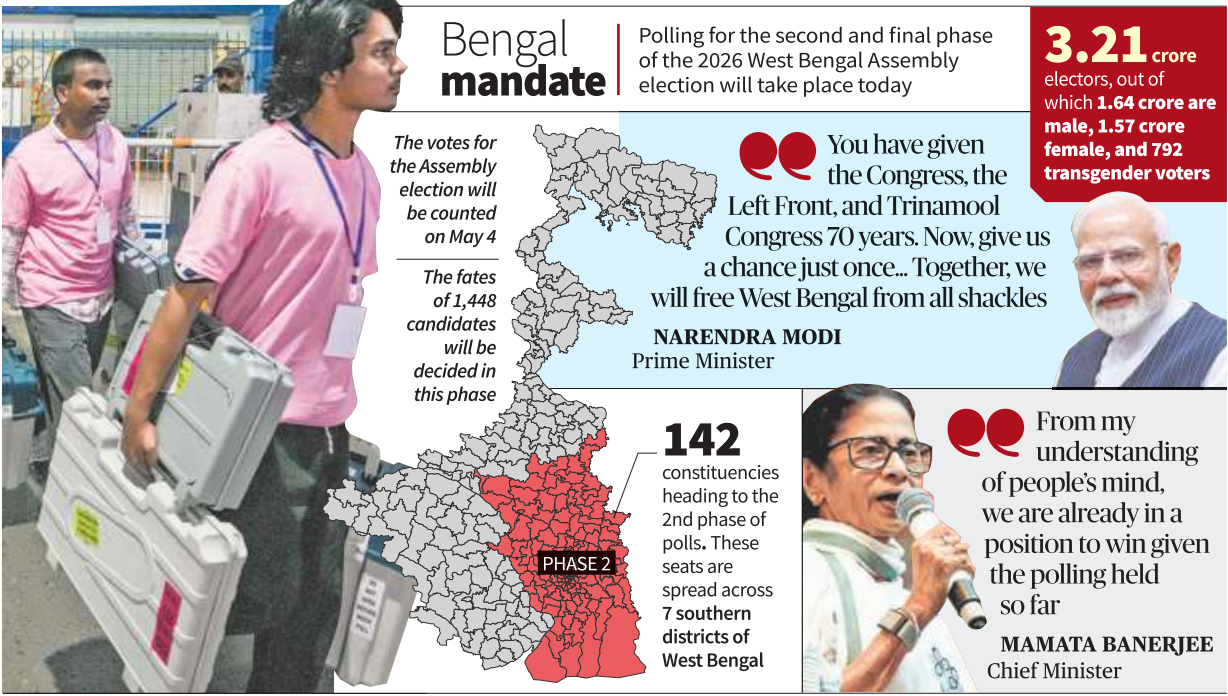
NEARBY
▼


'Govt. speaking to Anthropic about Mythos concerns'
CHENNAI
The Centre is speaking to Anthropic about the concerns over Mythos, a top official of the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology said here on Tuesday. » PAGE 6

Retired HC judge to probe varsity appointments
MADURAI
Retired High Court judge V. Bharathidasan is set to probe the alleged irregularities in the appointment of faculty in the Manonmaniam Sundaranar University in 2015-16. » PAGE 6

'Enough auto LPG stock available in T.N., Puducherry'
CHENNAI
Adequate stock of auto LPG was available at outlets run by public sector undertakings, a State-level coordinator for the oil industry has said. » PAGE 6

OPPORTUNITIES PAGE 5
► Over 160 Jobs in today's issue



Bengal mandate
Polling for the second and final phase of the 2026 West Bengal Assembly election will take place today
3.21 crore electors, out of which **1.64 crore** are male, **1.57 crore** female, and **792 transgender** voters
The votes for the Assembly election will be counted on May 4
The fates of 1,448 candidates will be decided in this phase
You have given the Congress, the Left Front, and Trinamool Congress 70 years. Now, give us a chance just once... Together, we will free West Bengal from all shackles
NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister
142 constituencies heading to the 2nd phase of polls. These seats are spread across 7 southern districts of West Bengal
From my understanding of people's mind, we are already in a position to win given the polling held so far
MAMATA BANERJEE
Chief Minister
REPORT ON: PAGE 11

UAE announces exit from OPEC group

Associated Press
DUBAI

The UAE announced on Tuesday that it will leave the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) effective May 1, stripping the oil cartel of one of its largest producers and further weakening its leverage over global oil supplies and prices.

Making the announcement via its state-run WAM news agency, the UAE said it would also be leaving the wider OPEC+ group, which Russia had led in order to try to stabilise oil prices.

"This decision reflects the UAE's long-term strategic and economic vision



The move had been rumoured as a possibility for some time with the UAE pushing back against production quotas in recent years. AFP

and evolving energy profile, including accelerated investment in domestic energy production, and reinforces its commitment to a responsible, reliable, and forward-looking role in global energy markets,"

the UAE said.

"Following its exit, the UAE will continue to act responsibly, bringing additional production to market in a gradual and measured manner, aligned with demand and market

conditions," it added.

The move had been rumoured as a possibility for some time, as the UAE pushed back in recent years against production quotas it felt had been too low – meaning it was not able to sell as much oil to the world as it had wanted.

The UAE has had increasingly frosty relations with Saudi Arabia, OPEC's largest producer, over political and economic matters in West Asia, even after both came under attack by fellow OPEC member Iran during the current war.

CONTINUED ON
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Anti-Terrorism Squad begins probe into Thane knife attack

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI

The Maharashtra Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) has initiated investigation into the alleged stabbing of two security guards in Thane district amid claims that the accused was linked to "anti-national activities", the police said on Tuesday.

The 31-year-old accused, Jabar Ansari, a chemistry instructor, allegedly attacked the two guards with a knife following an altercation on Monday morning.

Ansari, who had lived in



A sealing notice seen at the residence of Jabar Ansari in Maharashtra's Thane. PTI

the U.S. for some time, had allegedly approached the guards, employed at an under-construction building in the Naya Nagar area, Mira Road, seeking directions

to a mosque.

As per the police, the victims alleged that Ansari asked them to recite the 'Kalma' (Islamic verse) and attacked them with a knife when they were unable to do so.

Based on the CCTV footage from the area, the police identified the accused and apprehended him from his house in the same area. The police and the ATS later conducted a search at Ansari's residence.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Trump 'unhappy' with Iran's peace proposal

Reuters
DUBAI/WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump is unhappy with the latest Iranian proposal on resolving the two-month war, a U.S. official has said, dampening hopes for resolution of a conflict that has killed thousands, disrupted energy supplies, and fuelled inflation.

Iran's latest proposal would set aside discussion on its nuclear programme until the war, on hold following a ceasefire announced earlier this month, is ended and dis-

putes over shipping from the Gulf are resolved.

Mr. Trump, whose approval rates are falling amid domestic pressure to end a war for which he has given shifting rationales, is unhappy with the proposal as he wants nuclear issues dealt with from the outset, said a U.S. official briefed on the President's Monday meeting with his advisers.

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CHARLES III IN U.S.
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HC quashes money laundering case against Periyasamy

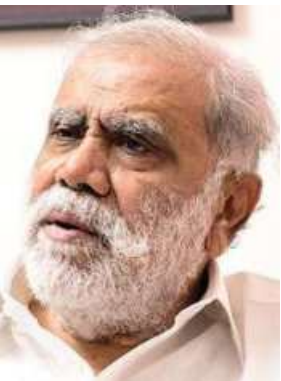
Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Tuesday quashed an Enforcement Case Information Report (ECIR) registered by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) in 2020 against Rural Development Minister I. Periyasamy, since a case related to the predicate offence had already been quashed by the court.

The First Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan allowed a petition filed by

the Minister and quashed the ECIR registered for alleged offences under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act on the basis of a case pertaining to an irregular allotment of housing plots.

The judges agreed with the Minister's counsel, K. Muthu Ganesa Pandian, that since the High Court had already quashed the case filed by the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC), there was no question of the existence of any proceeds of crime for which the ED could pursue the money



I. Periyasamy

laundering probe.

The DVAC had registered an FIR against Mr. Periyasamy in 2011 for having

allotted Tamil Nadu Housing Board plots at Kamara-jar Nagar in Thiruvannmiyur under the Government's Discretionary Quota while serving as the Minister for Housing in the DMK government between 2007 and 2011.

He was charged with having allotted the plots to retired IPS officer M.S. Jaffar Sait, his wife M. Parvin, and another individual for extraneous reasons.

The DVAC had said Ms. Parvin and another beneficiary, R. Durgashankar, had obtained the plots by identifying themselves as

social workers, but had entered into an agreement with real estate developer T. Udhayashankar of Landmark Construction for developing the property on receipt of a few crores of rupees.

In April 2025, Justice G.K. Ilanthiraiyan of the High Court quashed the DVAC case against Mr. Periyasamy, noting that the case had been quashed against all other accused for different reasons and, therefore, the charge of criminal conspiracy could not be sustained against a sole accused.



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INBRIEF



Paediatric haemodialysis machine donated to KKCTH

The Devayani Chandrakant Mohanlal Tolia Charitable Trust and the Rotary Club of Madras donated an advanced paediatric haemodialysis machine to Kanchi Kamakoti CHILDS Trust Hospital (KKCTH) on April 27. The machine, costing ₹17 lakh, can carry out different types of dialysis such as standard dialysis, slow long duration dialysis, plasmapheresis (blood purification), and dialysis on infants. Bala Ramachandran, head, Department of Paediatric Intensive Care Unit, KKCTH, thanked Chandrakant Tolia of the trust, and Nikhil Raj, president of the Rotary Club of Madras, for the donation, according to a press release.

Hotels association to hold B2B expo in city in October

The Tamil Nadu Hotels Association on Tuesday said that it will conduct UNAVU EXE 2026, a three-day B2B event featuring over 200 leading companies showcasing 500+ brands, at the Chennai Trade Centre from October 1. The association said that restaurants in the State had increased food prices only by 5% to 10% due to hike in commercial LPG prices.

City steps up preparedness for heat wave conditions

From Wednesday, Amma canteens will distribute oral rehydration salts to the public, while Metrowater has been directed to ensure the availability of clean drinking water at bus stops

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

Civic agencies such as Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) and Metrowater are set to strengthen preparedness for heat wave conditions in the city, following a meeting with senior officials of the State government.

At the meeting on Tuesday, to improve preparedness for heat wave conditions and take measures to manage and mitigate the impact of heat wave in the State, officials directed civic agencies to set up facilities for drinking water across the city. Chennai Metrowater has been directed to create infrastructure for clean drinking water in areas including bus stops and locations in the vicinity of public transport infrastructure.

Work on the construction of 70 shelters at road traffic junctions will be completed by GCC this week.



On standby: A five-bed heatstroke prevention ward was set up at the Kilpauk Government Medical College Hospital on Tuesday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

In a bid to mitigate heat wave conditions, GCC will start distribution of oral rehydration solutions in Amma Canteens and urban primary health centres across the city.

Starting Wednesday, anybody can walk in the Amma Canteen and demand an oral rehydration

solution to manage heat wave conditions, said an official. Similar to the work on creation of shelters at road junctions to reduce the impact of summer heat in various parts of the city, GCC will also set up digital boards to display the parameters pertaining to heat wave conditions and

share information about any abnormal rise in temperature and other parameters in each neighbourhood.

At least 100 digital boards will be erected this month to show the temperature and humidity and other parameters of heat wave conditions in the city.

Schools urged to avoid some activities on open spaces as temperature rises

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

As the State continues to sizzle under rising temperatures, the School Education Department has issued an advisory to principals, teachers, support staff, and students to protect themselves from the summer heat.

In a circular, the department said that open spaces exposed to direct sunlight during peak hours, especially during 12.00 p.m. and 3.00 p.m., must be avoided.

“Classes, games, or exercise for students outside during these hours must be avoided,” the advisory said.

Stating that awareness must be raised, they further said that students should be told about the need to drink adequate amounts of water.

“Students should be provided with opportunities to drink water at the beginning of each lesson and also be encouraged to

Dept. urges schools to avoid exposing children to direct sunlight during peak hours, especially during 12 p.m. to 3 p.m.

carry water while travelling,” said Director of School Education S. Kannappan.

Pointing out that indoor games can be played, he also noted that students are advised to use umbrellas while going out in the sun. The circular also added that bringing ORS, homemade lemon juice, buttermilk, and lassi should also be encouraged.

“School must be adequately stocked with ORS packets and first aid kits ready. Activities such as planting and maintaining trees in the school premises should be encouraged. Additionally, water containers for birds can also be placed in shade,” he added.

Contract employee held for watching leaked Jana Nayagan at vote counting centre

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A contract employee deployed in a CCTV surveillance room at the vote counting centre at Anna University was arrested by the city police after he allegedly downloaded and watched the recently

leaked film *Jana Nayagan*, starring Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) leader and actor Vijay, on his laptop, photographed it, and posted the image on social media, all while on duty.

Tight security
Electronic voting machines (EVMs) from five As-

sembly constituencies in the city— Saidapet, Virugambakkam, Velachery, T. Nagar, and Mylapore —were brought to the Anna University counting centre on the night of April 23 and kept under tight security.

Since April 16, CCTV cameras had been installed at the counting centre,

where the accused, T. Yuv-araj, 31, was working as a contract employee in the surveillance room.

Downloaded film
During duty hours, he allegedly downloaded and watched the film illegally on his laptop, took a photograph of it, and posted it

on his Facebook account around 11 p.m. on April 23.

Earlier, he had also uploaded on social media the temporary identity card issued to him by the Election Commission.

Based on a complaint lodged by an Information Technology official of the Greater Chennai Corpora-

tion, the police registered a case and secured the accused for inquiry.

A probe revealed that Yuv-araj hails from Panangudi in Thiruvavur district. He was working as a CCTV head for a private firm in Taramani, and holds a diploma in electrical and electronics engineering.



A screengrab of the employee's purported Facebook post shows Vijay's *Jana Nayagan* being played on a laptop.

Man held for sexual assault on elderly woman

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 57-year-old man was arrested for sexually assaulting a 76-year-old woman at her residence in Pulianthope.

The accused was identified as Maruthappan. The woman lived alone and her daughter visited her daily to assist in routine needs. According to the victim, during one such visit, a local plumber known to the family entered the house, sexually assaulted her and fled.

The victim was admitted to a government hospital. After her discharge, she lodged a formal complaint at All-Women Police Station, Pulianthope.

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On behalf of the President of India, Chief Workshop Engineer/Furnishing, Modern Coach Factory, Raebareli is inviting open e-tender(Tender Notice No. - M-200/MCF/RBL/UNPACKING & HK/2025-27, Date-25.04.2026) based on two packet i.e. Technical Bid & Financial Bid system online through Indian railway portal www.ireps.gov.in for following work :-
Description of work: Un packing of coach material and Housekeeping. Mechanized cleaning & scrap disposal of different Shops /sheds with Electrical production & All store Depot, Cleaning of Coaches and cobweb cleaning as per scope of work for 2 years. **Approx.Value of Work (₹)** 22,46,82,477.17 **EMD/ Bid Security(₹)** 12,73,400.00 **Quantity of work-**600 working days. **Work completion period:-** 24 Months. • E-Tender submitted through online up to 15:00 hrs. on 25.05.2026 . Manual offer will not considered. • E-Tender shall be opened on 25.05.2026 after 15:00 hrs. through online on <http://www.ireps.gov.in>. • Detailed Tender E-Tender Notice and Terms & conditions are available at Indian Railway IREPS website- <http://www.ireps.gov.in>.

Chief Workshop Engineer/Furnishing
E-Advised Tender Notice No. 05 ET/2026 Dated: 22.04.2026

S.N	Tender No.	Short Description	Qty.	Due Date
01	12251158	Bogie Bolster Assembly for Air Spring Type Fiat Bogie	1327 Nos	15/05/2026
02	03261179	Supply and Installation of Interior Panelling, Partition Frame and FRP Modular Toilet for Middle Basic Unit.	10 Set	20/05/2026

Corrigendum

01	85 ET/2025-26 Dated: 25.03.2026	Tender no. 03261162A	Due date may be read as 12/05/2026 Instead of 21/04/2026
02	01 ET/2026 Dated: 03.04.2026	Tender no. 03261127	Due date may be read as 30/04/2026 Instead of 20/04/2026
03	04 ET/2026 Dated: 08.04.2026	Tender no. 03251075B	Due date may be read as 06/05/2026 Instead of 22/04/2026

Website Address: www.ireps.gov.in & www.mcf.indianrailways.gov.in
Dy. CMM./Fur.

E-Advised Tender Notice No. 06 ET/2026 Dated: 22.04.2026

S.N	Tender No.	Short Description	Qty.	Due Date
01	03261127	Secondary Energy Absorber Assembly for LHB Amrit Bharat Coaches.	512 Nos	11/05/2026
02	06251135	Supply and apply of Epoxy Based Elastified Top Coat(2 Components)	214399 LTR	25/05/2026

Corrigendum

01	05 ET/2026 Dated: 22.04.2026	Tender no. 03261127	Due date may be read as 11/05/2026 Instead of 30/04/2026
02	04 ET/2026 Dated: 17.04.2026	Tender no. 04261110	Due date may be read as 07/05/2026 Instead of 27/04/2026

Website Address: www.ireps.gov.in & www.mcf.indianrailways.gov.in
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THE HINDU PRESENTS SCHOOL BUZZ
A Newspaper exclusively curated for School Students

ANNUAL DAY CELEBRATED
Pon Vidyashram Senior Secondary School, Valasaravakkam, celebrated their 21st Annual Day, Zenith '26, with elegance at the school premises. The theme, “Reaching New Heights,” reflected the institution's pursuit of excellence. The programme was presided over by Chairman Shri M. K. Rajagopalan, who conferred awards on outstanding students and teachers for their achievements and service. Chief Guest Mr. J. Angelo Irudayaswamy commended the school's commitment to holistic education. Guest of Honour Thenisai Thendral Deva delivered an inspiring address, while Special Guest Mr. Karikalan praised the students' performances. Cultural presentations showcased creativity, discipline and confidence, concluding the celebration memorably.

EARTH DAY CELEBRATED
Union Christian Public School, Chetpet, Chennai, celebrated Earth Day with purpose under the theme “Our Power, Our Planet”, highlighting that small actions can create meaningful change. Students participated in age-appropriate competitions. Std I to III took part in a colouring competition, while Std IV to VI engaged in a written quiz on sustainability. Std VII to IX expressed their thoughts through a poem writing competition. Senior students of Std X and XII presented impactful ideas through a poster making competition. The activities encouraged awareness, responsibility and mindful choices, empowering students to understand their role in protecting the environment.

KINDERGARTEN GRADUATION DAY
Vidya Mandir Matric Hr. Sec. School celebrated their 28th Kindergarten Graduation Day with enthusiasm, marking a milestone for young students stepping into primary education. Chief Guest Dr. S. Agnes Daney Angela of Dr. M.G.R. Fisheries College and Research Institute, Ponneri, distributed certificates and highlighted the importance of early childhood education. The event was held in the presence of Educational Advisor Mr. G. Purushothaman and Correspondent Mrs. G. Hemamalini Purushothaman. Principal Mrs. Dhanalakshmi Vijayan delivered the welcome address. Dressed in caps and gowns, the children celebrated their achievement, leaving parents and teachers with cherished memories.

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PERSONAL	SITUATION VACANT
CHANGE OF NAME I, Umaiyal W/o Parimelazhagan, R/o 363/B Nethaji Nagar, Vengikkal, Tiruvannamalai – 606604, Tamil Nadu, hereby declare that I shall henceforth be known as Uma. I, NATESA Shanmugam s/o Natesan, born on 17 Feb 1958, residing at Plot No. 245, S.Kolathur Main Road, Viduthalai Nagar, Kovilambakkam, Chennai-600129, have changed my name to Shanmugam N vide TN Gazette No.16 dated 22 Apr 2026 (806/111392) I, HELAN Jeyarani (Existing name of spouse as per change of Next -of -Kin POB/Service Documents), spouse of S.Dharmaraj, resident of F4, 1st Floor, B2 Block, SVS Apartment, Vivekanathar Street, Rajakipakkam, Chennai 600 073, have changed my name from Helan Jeyarani (Existing name of spouse as per change of Next -of -Kin POB/ Service Documents), to D. Jeyarani (proposed) adopted New Name) vide Affidavit dated 25th day of April 2026 (25-04-2026) before Notary Public G.Gopalakrishnan, M.A.B.L., Selayur. I, PAVITHRA Dhanraj, d/o; Dhanraj, i/o;No-99, Perumal Kovil Street, Gummidipoondi, Perapullyur, Tiruvallur-601206, Have changed my name as Pavithra Dhanaraj. OLD AGE HOME PALLIATIVE CARE at your home Trained Nurses, 24/7, Dr., Physio visits, Lab tests 1800-313-1883 tikotra.com/seniors BUSINESS OFFERS INVESTMENTS INVITED for a Renowned Company. An Annual Interest Rate of 18% will be provided. 9790794403 SHORT-TERM BUSINESS Loans for MSME Co. Fast Processing, No Upfront Charges Ct: 8438319150 EDUCATIONAL GENERAL SCHOOL CONSULTANCY provided Academics & Administration Full Time / Part Time. Contact :8940190432 achieversacademyconsultancy@gmail.com VACANCIES WANTED VICE-PRINCIPAL, PG in Chemistry, Physics, Maths, P.E, Graphix Designer. : avimhsschool@gmail.com HEALTH HAPPY FOOT SPA Reflexology Come as 2 & Pay 1 – @ Alwarpet. 72004 05144 MARRIAGE HALLS AYSWARYA MAHAL Arumbakkam available on 03 & 4th June 26. 9940657137	FINANCE Wanted LADY ACCOUNTS MANAGER 5-10 Yrs. Exp. Strong in Accounts, TDS, GST, MIS, Tally, P&L finalisation. "Age preferably 35-40 years" Work Hrs.: 10 AM – 6:30 PM. Sat+ Sun Holiday. Good salary. Email: y96000@hotmail.com GARMENTS Sr. Sales Manager (Bldg Materials) @ Chennai Exp -15-20 Yrs. 8925525853 GENERAL MANAGEMENT & MENTOR Role @India's Top 4th Company for VRS/Retired/ NRIs. Regular Income Age:40+. 9566022559 JOB P/F Time Admin/Mang.Role Regular Pay, Age40+. Field, VRS. 8610154833 BSC CHEMISTRY Fresh / Experience Male – Age Below 30 Years, Work Place Vallam, Sipcot (Chennai) Food Accommodation can be Arranged 9444074727 HIRING TEAM Handling & Consultants Pay above 1Lac M/F Preferable 40+ VRS, Rtrd NRI Return. Ct: 9176113474 NEED TELUGU/ Malayalam Co-Ordinator Age Upto 35. Work Location West Mambalam. Salary upto 17K. 9629641679 MARKETING FRESH/EXP MKRT Exe/Managers to Sell CMDA/DTCP Plots.40K+Inc 7708498266 BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT Engineers Wanted for Chiller Co@ Thirumazhisai SIDCO. Ct: VGS Raghavendra 9790753377 MEDICAL FEMALE SONOLOGIST or Radiologist Wanted for an Ultrasound Scan Centre in Perambur as Partner. 9941817990 TECHNICAL REQ. MIN 5yrs Exp Site Engg. for Hostel Project site at Siruseri mail: sales@stoneboutique.in 98408 79697 REQ SITE Engr/Mylapore Dip Civil/ BE Civil/Skill in site work, Age:30+Accountant (F). Padi W. A:9840091883 Mail@: vijaymuralibuilder@gmail.com

Uthandi residents raise concern over flood canal project

The ₹91-crore project by the Water Resources Department involves constructing a 1.05-kilometre canal linking the Buckingham Canal to the Bay of Bengal at Uthandi to tackle flooding in south Chennai; residents question why more straightforward alternatives were not pursued; they also fear that the canal itself could face blockages from silt or sand, leading to backflow and flooding

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Residents of VGP Layout in Uthandi have raised concerns over the proposed Straight-Cut Flood Escape Channel project by the Water Resources Department (WRD), warning that it could cause significant environmental damage, and impact critical groundwater resources.

The ₹91-crore project is intended to tackle recurring flooding in south Chennai, especially in low-lying areas around the Palikaranai marsh. It involves constructing a 1.05-kilometre canal linking the Buckingham Canal to the

Bay of Bengal at Uthandi, with a planned discharge capacity of up to 550 cusecs.

In a citizens' report released on Tuesday, residents question why more straightforward alternatives were not pursued. For instance, restoring and dredging the Buckingham Canal or improving the flow at the Muttukadu estuary could address the underlying issues like silt buildup, tidal backflow, and encroachments.

Instead, they argue, the current proposal introduces a new canal through a densely populated residential area, potentially creating new risks rather than solving existing ones.

There are also concerns that the canal itself could face blockages from silt or sand, leading to backflow and flooding within the neighbourhood during heavy rains.

Ecological concerns

The proposed outlet is located on Uthandi beach, which is considered ecologically sensitive and serves as a nesting site for Olive Ridley turtles. Residents say that releasing such a large volume of water at high speed could erode the shoreline, flood nesting areas, and disrupt the turtles' breeding cycle.

They also pointed to possible violations of Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ)



Public pushback: Residents argue that the proposal introduces a new canal through a densely populated residential area, potentially creating new risks rather than addressing existing ones.

norms. According to the report, the canal is expected to carry sewage-contaminated water from the Buckingham Canal directly

to the coast without sufficient treatment.

The report says that another major issue is the canal's path through a de-

signed aquifer recharge zone, one of the city's last remaining sources of fresh water.

Independent testing of samples indicates that water in the Buckingham Canal already contains high levels of contamination, including faecal coliform and biochemical oxygen demand well above permissible limits. Residents warn that channeling this water through sandy, porous terrain could allow pollutants to seep into the ground, permanently affecting drinking water quality.

Fishing communities

The project could also have a direct impact on nearby fishing communi-

ties, particularly in Nainarkuppam, located less than 500 metres from the proposed discharge point. Traditional shore-based fishing depends on stable beach conditions, and residents say erosion and polluted discharge could disrupt fishing areas and affect marine life, putting livelihoods at risk.

Residents have also flagged that the work has commenced without prior CRZ clearance or public consultation. The matter has since reached the National Green Tribunal (NGT), which has taken *suo motu* cognisance, and work on the project is currently on hold.

Despite this, they say

the District Coastal Zone Management Authority has moved the project forward for further approval, even though several concerns remain unresolved.

Residents have called on authorities to acknowledge the gaps and inconsistencies in the proposed project, recognise the significant environmental and social risks it poses, and deny approval in its current form to prevent potential long-term damage.

They also urge reconsidering the approach to flood mitigation by considering less disruptive alternatives that address root causes such as poor maintenance and encroachments.

52-year-old man kills self after murdering wife in Nanganallur

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 52-year-old man was found dead after reportedly murdering his wife at their residence in Nanganallur, following a domestic dispute.

The police said Subramani, 51, and his wife Nagalakshmi, 41, were living in an apartment at Thillai Ganga Nagar in Nanganallur.

The couple had two sons who were studying. One was living abroad and the other was with them in Chennai.

On Monday, their son left home around 6.10 a.m. for college. Subramani and Nagalakshmi were at home at the time. When he returned around 3 p.m., he found the main door open.

On entering the house, he noticed blood-stained footprints across the hall. When he went into a room, he was shocked to find his mother, Nagalakshmi, lying in a pool of blood. Crying out in distress, he rushed to another room, where he found his father, Subramani, lying dead. He immediately alerted the police.

The Adambakkam police rushed to the spot, recovered the bodies, and

sent them to a government hospital for post-mortem examination.

Frequent quarrel

Preliminary inquiries revealed that the couple frequently quarrelled over debts. Subramani also harboured suspicions regarding Nagalakshmi's interactions.

She ran a silk saree shop in Thillai Ganga Nagar and had reportedly incurred significant debts through her business.

Police sources stated that Subramani often questioned her over her professional interactions, and about certain videos she posted on YouTube, which led to frequent arguments. These disputes had been going on for the past two years.

While the police suspect that Subramani murdered his wife and then died by suicide, the police are also probing the possibility of a third person's involvement, considering the door of their house being open.

(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on the State's health helpline 104, TeleMANAS 14416, and Sneha's suicide prevention helpline 044-24640050).

Four-year-old killed, three injured in road accident

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A four-year-old boy was killed and three others were injured after a goods carrier hit them while they were crossing the road near Porur toll plaza.

The deceased was identified as Riyan Felix. Felix's mother, Glory, and her sister, Kiruba, travelled with their children to Sivagangai, to cast their votes in the Assembly elections.

On Tuesday morning, they returned to the city by bus and got down near Porur toll plaza. As they attempted to cross the road a flower-laden goods carrier from Maduravoyal hit them. Riyan Felix died on the spot. Glory, Kiruba, and Kiruba's six-year-old son sustained injuries and were admitted to a hospital for treatment. The Traffic Investigation Wing, Maduravoyal, have registered a case and are investigating.

Timings CHENNAI		
WEDNESDAY, APR. 29		
RISE	05:50	SET 18:24
RISE	16:33	SET 03:58
THURSDAY, APR. 30		
RISE	05:49	SET 18:24
RISE	17:21	SET 04:34
FRIDAY, MAY. 01		
RISE	05:49	SET 18:24
RISE	18:10	SET 05:12

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	39	26
Chennai Airport	38	28
Chennai City	35	28

Chennai Airport Today
39°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be hot and uneasy. Night also will be comfortable. Dry weather to occur.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
38°C The weather will be dry. Day will be slightly hot and uneasy. Night will be comfortable.

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M CH-CHE

INBRIEF



Vaidhya Veeraraghavaswamy temple car festival held

Thousands of devotees witnessed the *Ther* procession of the utsava idols of Sri Vaidhya Veeraraghavaswamy and Sridevi and Bhodevi Thayars held in Tiruvallur town on Tuesday. The idols were brought to the 55-foot-tall, 32-foot-wide to the chariot at 5.15 a.m. and the procession around the mada streets began by 7.30 a.m. and ended at 9.45 a.m. As the chariot, which weighs 75 tonnes, moved, the chants of *Govinda Govinda* rent the air. After the deities returned to the nelai, the starting point, Thirumanjanam was performed. The procession was conducted as part of the temple's annual Chithirai Brahmotsavam that began on April 22 with the hoisting of the flag. The temple, which is one of the 108 Divyadesams of the Sri Vaishnavas, is under the control of the Sri Ahobila Mutt. The temple officials, district administration, and the police had made elaborate arrangements for the smooth conduct of the festivities.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (April 29, Wednesday), the following articles are available:

■ On TCS harassment and conversion case newsth.live/w940ne

■ Why science and scientists must learn to celebrate failures newsth.live/sciencefailures

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Police step up crackdown on underage driving across city

Joint Commissioner of Police (Traffic) P. Vijayakumar says that eight cases have been filed this year against parents who had permitted minors to drive; a total of 58 cases were booked last year

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

To tackle underage driving, a growing problem in the city, parents of underage persons who are involved in road accidents are being arrested and remanded.

The Greater Chennai City Police (GCTP) has also decided to step up surveillance as the summer holidays, a period when minors are more likely to take vehicles on to the city roads, have begun.

Accident in Velachery

In an incident on March 7, a minor riding a motorcycle on Velachery 100 Feet Road near Murugan Kalyana Mandapam hit a 58-year-old pedestrian who was crossing the road. The victim sustained grievous injuries and later died at the hospital. The rider also suffered serious injuries.

Following this, a case was registered and a probe launched by the Adyar Traffic Investigation Wing. Inquiry revealed that the motorcycle had been handed over to the rider by his friend's father, who was aware that the rider was underage.

Based on the findings, the police registered a case



Dangerous ride: Police say regular awareness programmes are conducted in schools to educate students about the dangers of underage driving and the legal consequences involved. FILE PHOTO

against the juvenile and arrested the friend's father for abetment. He was later remanded in judicial custody.

Strict watch

P. Vijayakumar, Joint Commissioner of Police (Traffic), said, "We are consistently enforcing laws against those who allow minors to operate vehicles.

Last year, we booked 58 cases against parents and others who permitted minors to drive, and eight cases have been registered so far this year.

In fatal accidents involving minors, parents or those responsible are remanded."

He added that regular awareness programmes are conducted in schools to educate students about the dangers of underage driving and the legal consequences involved.

Penalties

Under Section 199A of the Motor Vehicles Act, if a juvenile commits an offence, the guardian or vehicle owner is deemed guilty, unless they can prove lack

of knowledge. They may face imprisonment of up to three years and a fine of ₹25,000. The law also provides for cancellation of the vehicle's registration and disqualification of the juvenile from obtaining a driving licence until the age of 25.

The GCTP have urged motorists to drive responsibly, follow traffic rules, and remain mindful of the value of human life. Parents have been warned against allowing or encouraging minors to drive vehicles.



Chess champion Viswanathan Anand acknowledged the role of volunteers who encouraged blood donation and congratulated MVBB for their dedication. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Madras Voluntary Blood Bureau holds golden jubilee event

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

At the golden jubilee award function of The Madras Voluntary Blood Bureau (MVBB) on Tuesday, speakers traced the journey of mobilising voluntary blood donors to ensure reliable and steady supply of blood for hospitals. Donors, institutions and organisations that played a role in promoting voluntary blood donation received awards on the occasion.

Taking part in the event, Viswanathan Anand, chess champion, acknowledged the role of volunteers who spread the word on blood donation and congratulated MVBB for their dedication. He also released an album on the occasion.

Recalling the situation 50 years ago in Tamil Nadu, Shanthi Ranganathan, founder of MVBB, said then, hospitals depended on professional donors, who donated blood for an exchange of ₹10 and a loaf of bread. They were mainly rickshaw pullers and porters, often those malnourished and weak. Educated people were not aware that blood donation was safe and can be done once every three months. Due to the shortage of healthy donors, blood quality was often compromised and hospitals faced severe shortages, she said.

MVBB founder Shanthi Ranganathan says T.N. stands at the forefront of voluntary blood donation

MVBB, she said, emerged as a pioneer organisation to take forward awareness of voluntary blood donation in industries, colleges, and offices.

"Misconceptions were widespread, and people feared health complications after blood donation," she said.

"Today, Chennai and Tamil Nadu stand in the forefront of voluntary blood donation with a reliable supply of blood for the medical sector. Chennai is a major medical hub and healthcare destination, serving patients across India and the world," she added.

R. Rajkumar, president of Association of Voluntary Blood Donors, Tamil Nadu, emphasised the need for young volunteers to sustain the movement, and urged Mr. Viswanathan Anand to bring chess lovers together on a particular day for blood donation.

The *Hindu's* team was among those awarded on the occasion. Among others, Bhanu Raghunathan, honorary secretary, MVBB, was present.

Art therapy is expanding mental health support: therapists

Sahana Mira S
CHENNAI

Not every art session is art therapy, says professional art therapy facilitator Dayaline Sivakumar from Chennai. "An usual art session could be called as the therapeutic art, at best," says her. With conversations dispelling the stigma around mental health care, art therapists and facilitators say that Chennaites are also leaning on art therapy for support, as well as more psychologists are enrolling in one-year diploma courses in the field than before.

"For some, it is easier to express things through creative mediums that are otherwise difficult to talk about, which is one of the

main concepts of art therapy," says Ms. Sivakumar who provides from watercolours to collage and other tactile art supplies, where the clients intuitively pick what resonates with them or with guidance. "It is more about giving shape to their emotions rather than drawing itself. They could be sketching lines, a question mark or even a wheel cart. Sometimes it may seem vague with just colour on paper, but it eventually opens deeper emotions," she says, adding that it supports people across mental health conditions including Post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD).

Art therapist Augustine Thilak from the city said that the process is more



Soothing exercise: Sometimes it may seem vague with just colour on paper, but it eventually opens deeper emotions, says professional art therapy facilitator Dayaline Sivakumar.

important than the final output. He prefers mediums such as watercolours, charcoal, and clay in his sessions, adding these mediums would not let them hold back. "It does not start with form always; so-

metimes it starts with colour, and then we see a form. At times, certain emotions and feelings can't be expressed verbally which is where art therapy comes into place," adds Mr. Thilak who also works

in Eurythmy (movement) therapy.

"Art therapy is what let me actually talk about the things I have been going through including self-loathing. It also comes down to the facilitator you work with. And when I sketch, I am not bothered about making it look good because that is not the point of it," says a 22-year-old student from Chennai, requesting anonymity.

Mr. Thilak says the awareness on art therapy is only recent, although he has been practising it in Chennai for over two decades. "Lately, we have seen more people in age group 18 and 30 coming in. Otherwise, those above 55 are also getting benefitted from it," he says, adding

that he started his work in art therapy with children with intellectual disabilities. Moreover, after the session, therapists alongside clients look for symbols, recurring themes, and patterns to arrive at insights that could help the individual further.

When 'therapy' too has become a buzzword, thrown around casually for any activity, misconceptions around this concept persist. "Unless you're trained in psychology, art, and art therapy, you can't run a one-on-one art session and call it therapy," adds Mr. Thilak. "Many people still ask me if they need to know art to attend a session which is also a common misconception," adds Ms. Sivakumar.

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S. Mahaveer Chand Bothra

WVC Chennai gets new office-bearers

CHENNAI: World Veg Council (WVC) Chennai has announced a new team of office-bearers for 2026. S. Mahaveer Chand Bothra, managing director, White Fire Diamond India Pvt. Ltd., is the international president and director, Sudhakar Narayanaswamy, managing director, Devi Narayan Exporters Pvt. Ltd., is international secretary and director, and R. Murali Rao, chief executive officer, Brindavan Group of Schools, Chennai, is the international treasurer and director, according to N. Tarachand Dugar, Founder-International President and Director, and chairman, Dugar Group of Companies, Chennai.

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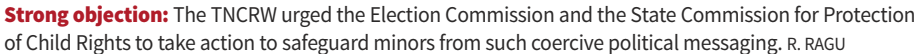
Dr. Amrutha Mahalakshmi
Ophthalmologist

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Students with disabilities allege denial of hall ticket

Migrant worker dies after inhaling toxic fumes

Four other workers who suffered from breathing difficulties continue to receive treatment.



provided to children. They urged the EC to initiate an immediate inquiry into the creation and dissemination of such videos. "Take action under the Model Code of Conduct and relevant electoral laws... and direct the concerned political leadership to publicly discourage such harmful practices," the letter said. They also urged the SPCPCR to issue a State-wide advisory prohibiting involvement of children in any political campaign or messaging.

Students said that the University's online payment portal had different categories of payments, including theory paper fee, application fee or registration fee, marks statement fee, and automation fee, to be paid before every semester-end examination. There were other payments, like provisional degree certificate fee, consolidated marks sheet fee, and convocation fee, that students were required to pay.

When contacted, officials of Thiruvalluvar University said that they had exempted students with benchmark disabilities from theory paper exam fees, which was the norm followed by most universities, including the University of Madras (UoM) and Periyar University. UoM officials, too, confirmed that they only waived off the theory paper exam fees.

In a letter to the Higher Education Secretary recently, Mr. Govindakrishnan has pointed out this anomaly and stated that it was a "gross violation of the Higher Education Department's order".

The Greater Chennai Police have advised the public not to post or share unverified or misleading content, videos, or images related to the incident. Strict legal action will be taken against those spreading rumours.

‘More visitors’
Highways officials said that the festival has been witnessing a steady rise in the number of pilgrims visiting

— THE  HINDU —

OPPORTUNITIES

GENERAL



भारतीय रिज़र्व बैंक सर्विसज़ बोर्ड

RESERVE BANK OF INDIA SERVICES BOARD



Advt. No. RBISB/BA/01-2026-27

Recruitment for the Posts of Officers in Grade 'B' (Direct Recruit-DR) (On Probation)- (General/DEPR/DSIM) Cadres - Panel Year - 2026 in Reserve Bank of India

Applications are invited for recruitment to the following posts in the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) for the Panel Year - 2026:

Sr. No.	Name of the Post	Vacancies
1	Officers in Grade 'B' (DR)- General	40
2	Officers in Grade 'B' (DR)- Department of Economic and Policy Research (DEPR)	10
3	Officers in Grade 'B' (DR)- Department of Statistics and Information Management (DSIM)	10
Total		60

2. For all other details such as eligibility criteria, reservation of vacancies, scheme of selection, submission of online application and other instructions, please refer to the detailed advertisement to be published on the Bank's website (www.rbi.org.in) on **April 29, 2026 (tentatively)** and in the Employment News/ Rozgar Samachar issue dated **May 02, 2026 / subsequently issue**. Candidates can apply for the aforementioned posts only by online mode through the Bank's website (www.rbi.org.in).

3. Important Dates **:

Website Link Open - For Online Registration of Applications and Payment of Application Fees/Intimation Charges	April 29 to May 20, 2026 (11:00:00 PM)
Phase-I Online Examination of Grade 'B' (DR) - General	June 13, 2026
Phase-I Online Examination of Grade 'B' (DR) - DEPR (Paper-I and II) / DSIM (Paper-I)	June 14, 2026
Phase-II Online Examination for Grade 'B' (DR) - General	July 25, 2026
Phase-II Online / Written Examination for Grade 'B' (DR) - DEPR (Paper-I and II) / DSIM (Paper-I and II)	July 26, 2026

**** The Board reserves the right to make any changes in the above dates.**

NOTE: Corrigendum, if any, issued on the above advertisement, will be published only on the Bank's website (www.rbi.org.in).

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INBRIEF



Karnataka HC issues notice to CBI on ex-Minister's appeal

The High Court of Karnataka on Tuesday ordered the issue of a notice to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on a petition filed by Congress MLA and former Minister Vinay Kulkarni challenging a special court's order convicting and sentencing him to imprisonment for life for the murder of BJP leader Yogeshgouda Goudar in Dharwad in 2016. Kulkarni will not be able to continue as legislator if the court refuses to stay his conviction.

Bullet train to link A.P. and Telangana capitals: Vaishnaw

The travel time between Andhra Pradesh capital Amaravati and Telangana's Hyderabad will be cut to 70 minutes (from eight hours at present) on the proposed high-speed rail corridor, Union Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said on Tuesday. He also announced that the South Coast Railway zone, a long-standing demand from A.P., would be notified on June 1. The bullet train project will link Amaravati, Hyderabad, Chennai, Bengaluru, Pune and Mumbai, he said.

Two assailants hack journalist to death in Chittoor district

Two unidentified assailants hacked to death a vernacular newspaper journalist in Chittoor district of Andhra Pradesh on Tuesday. The victim was identified as Jagannathan Reddy, 30. Police sources said Reddy had differences with a person with criminal antecedents and this might have led to the killing. Expressing concern, the Indian Journalists Union said the attack occurred just days after Reddy had published reports on the sandalwood mafia in Chittoor district.

Fuel supply stabilises in A.P.; crisis continues in Telangana

The Hindu Bureau
VISAKHAPATNAM/CHITTOOR

Fuel supply began stabilising across Andhra Pradesh on Tuesday, after days of widespread supply disruptions, long queues and panic buying.

However, panic buying continued for the second day in Telangana, particularly in Hyderabad.

In Andhra Pradesh, many petrol bunks resumed operations as the authorities stepped up efforts to address the issue. Petrol bunks saw shorter queues compared to Monday.

Dealers said the supply disruption seemed to be an engineered crisis. Oil companies had recently brought in a 'no-credit' policy, seeking immediate payment, they said. Many bunk operators, unable to clear old dues for want of credit, faced interruptions in supply.

Unverified messages on social media added to the panic, a dealer said.

Three factors

In Hyderabad, long queues were seen outside petrol pumps on Tuesday.

The Telangana Civil Supplies department said three key factors were behind the demand surge. Following the recent hike in industrial diesel price to ₹150 a litre, several commercial users were buying the fuel from retail outlets where the price is around ₹95 a litre. Two, supply issues in neighbouring States have driven out-of-State buyers into border districts of Telangana.

Rumours of a post-election price increase have also led to panic buying.

Kerala HC initiates contempt action over State-wide hartal

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court has initiated suo motu contempt of court action on Tuesday over a State-wide hartal, called by Dalit and Adivasi organisations in connection with the death of BDS student Nithin Raj.

A Division Bench of Justices Basant Balaji and P. Krishna Kumar directed the DGP (Law and Order) to submit a report by the evening on the alleged violent incidents and traffic hold-ups in different districts after hartal supporters blocked roads and forced the closure of shops. The court also issued notice to those who gave the hartal call.

The court had, in multiple judgments earlier, held



Protesters block vehicles in Kottayam. VISHNU PRATHAP

that loss or damage to members of the public and to the government during hartals and strikes would be deemed illegal and unconstitutional, and would invite contempt action.

90 people detained

The DGP submitted that a total of 27 cases were registered, including against

those who blocked an ambulance at Thiruvalla and those who stopped public transport buses in Thiruvananthapuram. In addition, over 90 people were arrested in connection with the hartal. He said police personnel had been instructed to prevent hartal supporters from blocking private vehicles.

The court directed the State government to file the submissions and posted the matter for hearing on May 1.

Nithin Raj, a student at the Anjarakandy Dental College in Kannur, was found dead on the campus on April 10. The death had snowballed into a major controversy, with his family and student groups accusing faculty members of caste discrimination.

Cong. district leader gets notice for publishing ad on Chennithala

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) has issued a show-cause notice to Thiruvananthapuram District Congress Committee (DCC) general secretary A. Prajin Babu, who published a full-page focus feature advertisement on the political journey of senior leader Ramesh Chennithala in an English newspaper.

The notice was issued on the charge of embarrassing the party in public in violation of the Congress's political positions and directives.

KPCC president Sunny Joseph viewed the act as a

serious breach of discipline and directed the general secretary in charge of organisational affairs, Neyyattinkara Sanal, to issue the show-cause notice to Mr. Babu.

The All India Congress Committee (AICC) and the KPCC had previously directed that the Congress leaders and workers not make public statements in print, visual, social media or any other platform in a manner that bring disrepute to the organisation, particularly regarding the selection of the Chief Minister after the elections.

The show-cause notice was issued to Mr. Babu, acting in contravention of this directive, by publish-

ing the advertorial tracing Mr. Chennithala's political journey from his days as a Kerala Students Union (KSU) activist to his rise as a national leader.

Internal tussle

The KPCC has warned of further disciplinary action if Mr. Babu does not submit a detailed and proper explanation to the party leadership within three days of receiving the notice.

The show-cause notice is the latest flashpoint in a widening internal dispute within the Congress over who will become Chief Minister if the UDF wins the 2026 Assembly elections, the results for which are due on May 4.

Google's AI data hub project kicks off in Andhra Pradesh

Chief Minister Naidu lays foundation for 1-gigawatt centre on 600 acres on Vizag outskirts; it will be one of India's largest FDI projects with data storage, AI cloud, at an investment of ₹1.35 lakh cr.

V. Kamalakara Rao
VISAKHAPATNAM

Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday laid the foundation stone for the Google Data Centre at Tarluvada, on the outskirts of Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh, one of the largest single Foreign Direct Investment projects in India.

The 1-Gigawatt hyperscale AI data centre is coming up on 601.4 acres at an investment of ₹1.35 lakh crore. It will be managed by Google's subsidiary Raiden Infotech in partnership with Adani Infra. AdaniConneX and Airtel Nxta are also partners in the wider Google-Adani-



The project will be managed by Google's subsidiary Raiden Infotech in partnership with Adani Infra. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Airtel venture, which forms part of Google's announced \$15 billion investment.

Subsea cable boost

The facility will offer large-scale data storage along

with AI cloud infrastructure, and an upcoming subsea cable system will give Visakhapatnam direct digital links with several countries.

Union Minister for Electronics and Information

Technology Ashwini Vaishnaw said the port city was set to become India's next technology landmark. "Visakhapatnam will become AI-patnam," he said.

Adani Digital Labs Director Jeet Adani said India currently had about 1.3 Gigawatts of total data centre capacity, and that the Visakhapatnam project alone would add nearly 1 Gigawatt at a single location.

Laura Williams, Consul General at the U.S. Consulate General in Hyderabad, said the Google project embodies the strength of the U.S.-India partnership.

SECOND CENTRE
» PAGE 11

Why should third parties challenge faith or rituals in places of worship?

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The direct descendant in the Chishti-Nizami lineage associated with the Dargah of Hazrat Khwaja Nizamuddin Aulia in Delhi found common ground with the devotees and foster family of Lord Ayyappa, the deity at Sabarimala temple in Kerala, when he submitted in the Supreme Court on Tuesday that the faith of a believer could not yield to the whim of a third-party

interloper or a tourist to walk into the *sanctum sanctorum*.

Appearing before a nine-judge Constitution Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Syed Altamash Nizami said the basti in which the dargah was located and the hill on which the Sabarimala temple was situated were unique in the minds of the believers.

Advocate Nizam Pasha, appearing for Mr. Nizami, submitted that a particular

place of worship and the faith attached to it could not operate in other dimensions. It was not for third parties to challenge the faith, belief or mode of rituals attached to these distinctive places of worship. The location of the temple or the dargah and the peculiar rituals associated to them could not be segregated.

Mr. Pasha said the case of the dargah stemmed from an incident of a woman law student attempt-

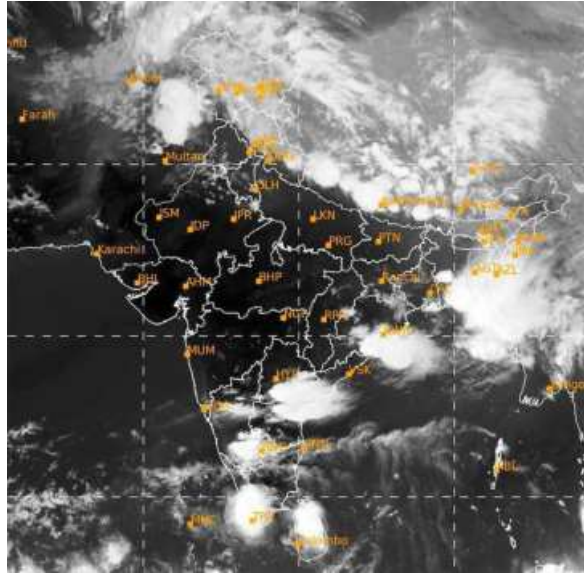
ing to enter the *sanctum sanctorum* of the dargah in declaration of her rights under the Sabarimala judgment.

Mr. Pasha said the mere fact that members of other faiths were not banned from entry did not take away the denominational character of a religious place of worship.

Mr. Pasha argued that core religious practices were impervious to social reforms and outside the reach of the State.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 18.15 HRS)

Forecast for Wednesday: Heavy to very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Assam, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura and Sikkim. Thunderstorm accompanied with lightning/gusty winds likely at isolated places over Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Puducherry

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	4	25.8	23.0	Kozhikode	37.9	29.0	
Ahmedabad	43.2	25.7		Kurnool	41.4	30.8	
Aizawl	26	25.3	16.8	Lucknow	39.7	26.4	
Allahabad	41.0	28.0		Madurai	39.0	27.5	
Bengaluru	35.4	25.0		Mangaluru	0.6	34.0	26.0
Bhopal	43.6	26.8		Mumbai	33.6	25.6	
Bhubaneswar	34.5	27.1		Mysuru	36.2	22.8	
Chandigarh	33.8	24.8		New Delhi	39.2	29.4	
Chennai	39.1	28.2		Patna	35.0	23.7	
Coimbatore	37.7	25.8		Port Blair	33.8	26.6	
Dehradun	34.7	21.8		Puducherry	35.6	27.9	
Gangtok	22.8	14.6		Pune	42.3	26.4	
Goa	35.0	28.3		Raipur	42.8	28.7	
Guwahati	10	29.1	21.4	Ranchi	0.4	38.2	25.8
Hubballi	34.0	23.0		Shillong	17	20.0	14.2
Hyderabad	42.0	27.7		Shimla	26.0	14.0	
Imphal	22.4	18.8		Srinagar	21.2	12.6	
Jaipur	40.9	28.0		Thiruvananthapuram	34.8	26.4	
Kochi	32.8	27.2		Tiruchi	40.5	27.6	
Kohima	21.0	15.0		Vijayawada	38.0	27.9	
Kolkata	34.2	28.7		Visakhapatnam	33.2	28.1	

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad	74	85	28	166	121	1	In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Kaithal.
Bengaluru	19	11	40	172	177	2	Haryana recorded an overall air quality index
Chennai	15	18	43	20	37	3	(AQI) score of 370
Delhi	24	129	44	140	313	4	indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In
Hyderabad	15	14	37	81	98	5	contrast,
Kolkata	10	35	38	57	59	6	Ramanathapuram, Tamil
Lucknow	11	30	21	232	156	7	Nadu recorded a healthy
Mumbai	3	12	49	44	108	8	AQI score of 16
Pune	1	22	115	42	76	9	
Visakhapatnam	23	42	24	41	113	10	

Air Quality Code: 1 Poor 2 Moderate 3 Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

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A false high

The SIRs impact must be factored in before reading turnout figures

There is a tendency in India to reduce democracy to the mere conduct of elections, and to confine political life to “political society” – that subset of the population actively engaged in setting policy and in mediating welfare delivery. This points to a democracy that falls short of a deliberative or deeply participative model, even in socio-economically better-off States such as Tamil Nadu (T.N.) and Kerala. Yet, elections are not a one-off event, and turnout remains a useful dipstick for the vibrancy of the democratic exercise, particularly in India where the poorer sections vote in large numbers. By that measure, the headline figures from T.N. and the first phase of the poll in West Bengal appear daunting and unprecedented. According to provisional Election Commission of India (ECI) data, 93.2% of voters turned out in the first phase in West Bengal and 85.1% in T.N. These record numbers must be read against the backdrop of the ECI’s Special Intensive Revision (SIR), which led to massive net voter deletions. In T.N., the rolls shrank by 10.5% from the pre-SIR figure, while in West Bengal nearly 13% of the electorate was deleted, with the eligibility of lakhs of voters still being heard by tribunals. If this is factored in, the percentage turnout begins to look inflated by a reduced denominator (total electorate) rather than by genuinely expanded participation (the numerator). The absolute increase in turnout in T.N. – about 27 lakh votes on provisional figures – was in fact among the lowest in recent electoral cycles, suggesting that wrongful deletions may have suppressed real participation even if the SIR did clear the electoral rolls of those who had died or moved out. The effect was sharpest in cities such as Chennai, where several constituencies recorded turnout above 80%, a jump of over 20 percentage points, even though the absolute number of voters – around 24 lakh – remained virtually unchanged from the 2021 elections.

It is also difficult to read too much into turnout in either State. High turnout has long been a feature of politically charged West Bengal, and T.N. has also been no slouch in recent electoral cycles compared to the rest of India. Also, political scientists have found little correlation between turnout levels and pro- or anti-incumbency outcomes. Once published, turnout percentages tend to acquire a life of their own and are cited as proof of democratic enthusiasm or the strength of a mandate, or, in T.N.’s case, the impact of a new political player such as actor Vijay’s Tamila-ga Vettri Kazhagam. But a percentage is only as meaningful as the denominator it rests on, and in these two States, the denominator itself has been substantially altered. Turnout figures must therefore be read alongside how the electorate was determined before any conclusions about the mandate are drawn from the actual results.

Battle of wills

The U.S. should lift its blockade so that Iran can open the Strait of Hormuz

The U.S. war on Iran has turned into a battle of wills in the Strait of Hormuz and the Gulf of Oman, marked by duelling naval blockades and stalled diplomacy. Iran, which has effectively restricted the free flow of traffic through the Strait of Hormuz since the U.S. and Israel attacks on February 28, has refused to ease its control over the critical waterway. The U.S. insists that its blockade of Iranian ports will stay in place until a deal is reached. Last week, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi travelled to Pakistan, which mediated the first round of direct talks on April 11, but Iran declined further direct talks with Washington. The White House had earlier said it would send special envoy Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner to Islamabad, but President Donald Trump cancelled their trip after Mr. Araghchi left the Pakistani capital. Mr. Trump has repeatedly said that Iran wants a deal. Yet, Tehran continues to refuse talks with the U.S., citing Israel’s attacks on Lebanon and America’s blockade in the Gulf of Oman. On paper, a ceasefire is in place in Lebanon, and Mr. Trump said earlier this month that Israel was “prohibited” from attacking the country, but Israeli air strikes have continued. He has also indicated no urgency to lift the blockade, betting that sustained economic pressure will force Iran to change its position.

The only silver lining is that the Iran ceasefire, announced on April 8, is still holding. Despite Mr. Trump’s threats, he has held fire even after Iran seized ships in the Persian Gulf. Tehran, too, despite warning retaliation over a U.S. seizure of an Iranian tanker, has not followed through. Both sides have remained diplomatically engaged through Pakistan. The alternative to diplomacy is disaster. The U.S. and Israel bombed Iran for 40 days but failed to secure a favourable strategic outcome, and the global economic fallout of this illegal war is now being felt. For diplomacy to succeed, Mr. Trump and the Iranian leadership should adopt a phased approach. Rather than acting as if the war has not changed the region’s strategic realities, the U.S. should offer tangible concessions to Iran in return for compromises on core issues. Iran has demonstrated a measure of deterrence by asserting control over the Strait of Hormuz. But if it continues to disrupt commercial traffic, further damaging the global economy, it risks squandering the goodwill it enjoys as the underdog. A practical first step would be reciprocal de-escalation: the U.S. lifting its blockade and Iran reopening the Strait to commercial shipping. This would also reinforce the fragile ceasefire and build confidence, paving the way for the next round of direct talks on outstanding issues, including the nuclear programme.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma of the Delhi High Court refused to recuse herself from hearing the Delhi liquor policy case – *Central Bureau Of Investigation vs Kuldeep Singh and Ors.* (April 20, 2026) – involving the former Chief Minister of Delhi, Arvind Kejriwal, and others. This episode marks an unfortunate deviation from India’s jurisprudence on judicial recusal.

Mr. Kejriwal argued the recusal plea by appearing as party in person in the High Court. He submitted that the judge should not hear the Central Bureau of Investigation’s plea against the discharge of the accused, including himself, in the excise policy case, as ordered by the trial court. The prominent grounds cited in his plea included adverse findings by the judge in earlier proceedings in the same case; the judge’s alleged ideological proclivity, as reflected in her attendance at events organised by the Akhil Bharatiya Adhivakta Parishad, or ABAP (a lawyers’ organisation inclined towards the political philosophy of the ruling regime at the Centre); the fact that the judge’s children were working as panel advocates under the Centre/government, with case files to be allotted by the Solicitor General, who, incidentally, was representing the opposing side in the case; and a statement by Home Minister Amit Shah implying that Mr. Kejriwal would lose the case in the High Court. Because of these factors, he contended that he reasonably apprehended bias in the process of adjudication.

Law on recusal

The law on recusal of a judge is not codified in India. It is more an ethical issue than a technical one. Yet, the jurisprudence on recusal is rich as it takes in precedents and best practices across the globe. The 19th century idea about judges with its Victorian overtones is reflected in the British case of *Leeson vs General Council of Medical Education and Registration* (1889) where Lord Bowen said that like Caesar’s wife, judges should be above suspicion. The proverbial idea that justice should not only be done but also be seen to have been done was articulated by *Lord Hewart in R vs Sussex Justices* (1923).

What transpired in the Delhi High Court exposes the risk of judges not strictly adhering to the Bangalore Principles of Judicial Conduct, the draft of which was finalised at the Round Table Meeting of judges from many countries at The Hague in 2002. They enumerate independence, impartiality, integrity, propriety, equality, competence and diligence as accepted ‘judicial values’. Among other things, they say that “a



Kaleeswaram Raj

Lawyer at the Supreme Court of India

Judicial recusal principles have been tested in the Delhi liquor policy case

judge shall avoid impropriety and the appearance of impropriety in all of the judge’s activities” .

In *Ranjit Thakur vs Union Of India And Ors.* (1987), the Supreme Court of India explained that the ‘proper approach’ for a judge when faced with a request for recusal “is not to look at his own mind and ask himself, however, honestly, ‘Am I biased?’, but to look at the mind of the party before him”. In *P.K. Ghosh, I.A.S. and Ant. vs J.G. Rajput* (1995) the Court said that when the litigant feels on reasonable basis that a particular judge should not hear his case, and when there are alternatives, recusal by the judge is the appropriate course, for maintaining public confidence in the system. In *State Of Punjab vs Davinder Pal Singh Bhullar and Ors. Etc.* (2011), the Court said that “a mere ground of appearance of bias and not actual bias is enough to vitiate the judgment/order”.

In *Supreme Court Advocates-On-Record Association vs Union Of India* (2015), the Court reiterated some of the judicial values. The judgment said, “The simple question is, whether the adjudication by the Judge concerned, would cause a reasonable doubt in the mind of a reasonably informed litigant and fair-minded public as to his impartiality.” Unlike administrative decision making, where the adjudicative authority is often stipulated in the statute or the rule, there is no doctrine of necessity in judicial proceedings when there are alternatives.

The judgment of the top court in *State of W.B. vs Shivananda Pathak* (1998) was an admonition against judicial obstinacy. Thus, with the possible exceptions such as Justice Arun Mishra’s refusal to recuse in *Indore Development Authority vs Manoharlal And Ors.* (2019), the Supreme Court has, by and large, rejected the “duty to sit doctrine” evolved in the United States.

The challenge before the judge

Legal scholar James Sample opined that “the teachable moments on disqualification are in the Court’s Court”. This, again, is a call not only for ensuring fairness but also for maintaining the appearance of fairness. The real challenge before the judge is to overcome the possibility for subjectivity in adjudicative process especially when the very same judge whose recusal is sought is deciding the question of recusal.

Distinguished American jurist Benjamin N. Cardozo famously wrote, “We may try to see things as objectively as we please. None the less, we can never see them with any eyes except our own.”. The maxim that no one should sit in judgment in her own cause is too well settled.

The RTE Act and the idea of social inclusion



Ayushi Khare

Senior Lead, Government Relations, Indus Action



Karthika Annamalai

Consultant, Right to Education (RTE), Indus Action

The Supreme Court of India’s judgment strengthens the vision of a socially integrated education system

schooling or to allow the state to outsource its constitutional duty to public education, citing falling government school enrolment alongside rising private school admissions.

This reading is misplaced. First, Section 12(1)(c) does not dilute the state’s duty to invest in public schools, but recognises that the right to free and compulsory elementary education, and the creation of shared learning spaces, must be realised within a schooling ecosystem where private schools are not incidental actors but natural participants in fulfilling a constitutional mandate. The RTE Act does not create a zero-sum contest between public and private institutions; it seeks to foster integrated educational spaces.

Second, the shift towards private schooling predates the RTE Act. The Annual Status of Education (ASER) Report of 2006 documents significant movement into private schools “at the expense of government school enrolment”. Declining admissions in government schools are rooted in deeper concerns around infrastructure, teacher presence, and perceived quality – not in Section 12(1)(c) itself.

Evidence from the ground

Since its rollout, over five million children have walked through the doors of educational spaces previously out of reach, with retention rates averaging over 90%. In cities such as Delhi and Ahmedabad, blended classrooms are no longer exceptions; they are the norm. Research (such as that by Rao, Gautam, 2019) indicates that mixed classrooms lead to increased generosity, reduced discrimination, and stronger pro-social behaviour, without any adverse impact on academic outcomes or classroom discipline. At scale, implementation has also stabilised: reimbursements under Section 12(1)(c) are centrally streamlined, and State-level online Management Information Systems (MIS) ensure

Viewed in the light of these principles, Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma should have recused herself or at least insisted that the recusal plea should be placed before another judge for hearing. Such a course would have facilitated a more objective evaluation of the contentions raised by Mr. Kejriwal apart from averting the present scenario. But neither of these happened and the present judgment followed.

Fairness of process

The judgment issued on April 20, 2026 does not reflect the correct judicial approach. The judge said that she had to decide between a litigant and herself. It was further stated in the judgment that the suspicion of bias expressed in the recusal plea was unfounded and that the allegations were manufactured. The judge asked, “... if the children of politicians can enter politics, how would it be just to question the children of a Judge who study like others, struggle like others, and prove themselves in Court like others to earn their livelihood?” One would wonder if this was the argument made by Mr. Kejriwal.

Mr. Kejriwal, in his rejoinder, had reportedly said that “conflict arises not from prior participation in the present proceedings, but from the admitted existence of a live, active and ongoing professional relationship with the prosecuting side”. The judge also justified her attendance at an event organised by the ABAP, and stated that she had attended events conducted by academic bodies as well. The judgment mistakes criticism of the judge as one of judicial establishment. The verdict is also self defensive, argumentative and accusational rather than analytical. It is vulnerable to further legal challenge. After the judgment, Mr. Kejriwal and Manish Sisodia wrote letters to the judge stating that they would not participate in further proceedings before her in the present matter.

In a case with serious political ramifications, the grounds raised by Mr. Kejriwal and others were relevant and required a more objective assessment, rather than a subjective affirmation based on a notion of a “presumption of impartiality”, as stated in the judgment. The verdict substitutes the well-settled legal position that a reasonable apprehension of bias is sufficient for a plea of recusal with a requirement to demonstrate actual bias. This is patently erroneous.

The judge rightly said that, in the recusal plea, she was effectively being tried by the litigant. But the outcome of this “trial”, unless corrected, will remain an embarrassing precedent for a system already in crisis.

transparent, low-discretion processing.

For children from disadvantaged backgrounds, these classrooms offer more than just academics. They provide access to social capital, previously unexplored aspirations, peer networks, and institutional cultures. These experiences translate into higher self-belief, enhanced ambition, and a broader worldview.

Acknowledging challenges

There is no denying the challenges that persist in the implementation of Section 12(1)(c). Some private schools continue to resist full inclusion, while families often bear hidden costs for uniforms, books and materials. Implementation remains uneven across States, with persistent gaps in transparency, grievance redress, and last-mile outreach and disbursements.

These challenges do not change the fact that Section 12(1)(c) was not meant to rely solely on moral persuasion – it requires clear, enforceable rules to succeed. Encouragingly, recent experience demonstrates that these gaps are neither inevitable nor insurmountable. State-driven digital admission systems and improved monitoring mechanisms – particularly in Rajasthan, Gujarat, and Delhi – have significantly strengthened access and accountability.

The Court’s reaffirmation of Section 12(1)(c) makes clear that it is neither a retreat from public education nor an endorsement of private schooling. The challenge now is administrative. States must ensure timely reimbursements, remove hidden costs by private schools, strengthen grievance redress, and enforce inclusion norms so that equality is experienced. The real test is whether we can operationalise the constitutional promise of social integration with the seriousness needed to match the ambition we hold for our children.

delays can be fatal. While infrastructure gaps may take time to address, training can be implemented immediately. Structured training in snakebite first aid, anti-snake venom administration, and anaphylaxis management must be made mandatory for all doctors. **Anahatha D. Kalyani**, Pallippuram, Palakkad, Kerala

Officials of the Kerala Forest Department have showcased “SARPA” (the Snake Awareness, Rescue, and Protection app) as a

tool that can help save the lives of snakebite victims and connect users with snake rescuers. However, the app is currently available only on the Android platform and can be downloaded only from the Google Play Store. I request the Forest Department to make the app available on the App Store as well, so that iPhone users can also benefit from it. **Surendran K.T.**, Kaloor, Ernakulam, Kerala

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The fight to eliminate cervical cancer

In 2008, Professor Harald zur Hausen received the Nobel Prize for his discovery that persistent infection with high-risk strains of the Human Papillomavirus (HPV) is the cause of cervical cancer, an important cause of morbidity and mortality globally, but more so in low and lower-middle-income countries (LMICs). His discovery paved the way for the development of prophylactic vaccines as well as tests to detect the infectious agent. A decade later, in 2018, the World Health Organization (WHO) announced an initiative for the elimination of cervical cancer, and the global strategy was formally launched on November 17, 2020, endorsed by 194 countries, India among them.

Disease and prevention
Cervical cancer is a source of extreme physical misery, emotional strife and financial hardship. It is the second most common cancer among women in India, with approximately one lakh new cases every year, and half as many deaths, which is one quarter of the global burden. The years of life lost to cervical cancer are more than that of other cancers as these women are relatively younger, with active family and social responsibilities. Women diagnosed with stage 4 cervical cancer could develop urinary fistulas, postmenopausal bleeding, extreme sciatic and lumbar pain, obstruction to their ureters and renal failure. If one is lucky enough to get diagnosed at an earlier stage, the cancer is curable, but only with radical surgery or chemo and radiation therapy. There is also a risk of recurrence which will require even more difficult exenteration procedures, stomas etc. That is, while the cancer is curable by providing symptom relief, hormone replacement and other supportive care, it comes at a physical and financial cost. However, such suffering was preventable. Since the 1940s, secondary prevention by regular



Neerja Bhatla
Professor Emeritus, National Cancer Institute Jhajjar, Former Head of Department of Obstetrics & Gynaecology, All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Delhi

Cumulative data from systematic trials and post-marketing surveillance show no increase in adverse events among vaccinated women than in the general population

pap smear screening had been set up in the West, enabling detection of not just cancer but also precancerous stages. The natural history of cervical cancer has been well documented for over a century. It has a long precancerous phase of 10-15 years termed Cervical Intraepithelial Neoplasia (CIN) which can be detected by the microscopic examination of cells collected on a slide by brushing the cervix. At this stage, the cancer can be easily treated by simple day care procedures that do not require the removal of the uterus. However, in India and other LMICs, we lacked the infrastructure and manpower to implement a screening of all women over the age of 30 years even once, let alone the recommended three-year interval period. Even in good tertiary centres, the laboratory placed a limit on the number of women that could be screened in a day. Outreach camps were conducted at regular intervals by gynaecologists and pathologists around the country, but these were merely a drop in the ocean. Even today, despite a national programme for screening with visual inspection, the screening coverage does not exceed 5%. Moreover, bringing women who test positive into the hospital for a confirmatory biopsy and treatment has extremely poor compliance rates.

The promise of a vaccine
HPV vaccination entered this scenario in 2006 like a superhero for the primary prevention of cervical cancer. Starting off as a three-dose vaccination, research showed that it could be reduced to two, and then it was found that just one dose was sufficient to provide protection against 85-90% of cancers. Over 500 million doses have been delivered worldwide, and nearly four million in India. Cumulative data from systematic trials and post-marketing surveillance show no increase in adverse events

among vaccinated women than in the general population. Transient mild reactions have been observed that are common to all vaccines. There have been no negative effects on reproductive performance, fertility rates, congenital malformations or menstrual patterns. The efficacy of the HPV vaccine is remarkable, with nearly complete protection against the strains which are present in the vaccine. The first generation of vaccines were directed against the two most virulent strains, HPV 16 and 18, that account for 70% of cervical cancers globally but 85% in India. Countries like Australia and the U.K. which introduced the HPV vaccine soon after its launch in 2007-8 have already witnessed significant reductions in pre-cancer and cancer. Similar reports have come from other countries like Sweden, Denmark, Canada and the U.S.

Widespread accessibility
The WHO's cervical cancer elimination initiative envisions making cervical cancer a rare cancer, with an incidence rate of four per 1,00,000. To reach this goal, we must achieve certain targets by 2030: HPV vaccination of 90% of girls before the age of 15 years, screening of 70% of women with an HPV test at 35 and 45 years, and treatment of 90% of those detected with lesions. While the country has already crossed the halfway point since the launch of the global declaration, we are still far away from reaching these targets. However, the launch of the National HPV Vaccination Campaign on February 28, 2026 by the Prime Minister himself signals the highest political commitment to women's health and reproductive rights. All parents need to be aware of this opportunity so that their 14-year-old daughters can avail free vaccination at the nearest government health facilities. One small jab will take us towards a cervical cancer-free future and a Viksit Bharat by 2047.

A question of choice

A retracted ban on government staff joining parties has led to intense debate

STATE OF PLAY

Shubhomoy Sikdar
shubhomoy.s@thehindu.co.in



An order by Chhattisgarh's Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government that at first glance seemed innocuous – and its hasty withdrawal – has triggered a debate on the political leanings of serving government employees.

On April 21, a circular issued by the General Administration Department – which comes under Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai – stated that no government employee could become a member of any political party or organisation; participate in any of its activities; or hold office within it. Referring to the provisions of the Chhattisgarh Civil Services (Conduct) Rules, it said that it was mandatory for all government servants to discharge the duties of their office with complete “impartiality, honesty, and integrity”. It also said that no government employee was to assume any position or responsibility that might affect his or her official duties. Further, the circular warned of action in accordance with the provisions of the Chhattisgarh Civil Services (Conduct) Rules, 1965, and the Chhattisgarh Civil Services (Classification, Control and Appeal) Rules, 1966 for violation of those rules.

However, the very next day another circular was issued which stated that the earlier instructions were suspended till further orders.

On attending RSS events
The suspension of the notice evoked a debate centred on the Rashtriya Swayamsewak Sangh (RSS). State Congress President Deepak Baij linked

both the circulars to the organisation. He said that with respect to the first order, it seemed to indicate that a section of the BJP government was targeting the RSS, angered by its interference in the government. The subsequent suspension, he claimed, was issued after the RSS expressed its displeasure. The BJP government used to pressure and lure employees to attend RSS events, but the April 21 order would have automatically put a stop to this, he said.

Invoking history, the Pradesh Congress Committee (PCC) president reminded that the RSS had been banned in the past and that many State governments had considered the RSS as “dangerous for the country”. He argued that government employees should never be given an exemption to join the RSS.

While there was no explicit mention of the RSS in the government's circular, the matter is understood to have ruffled a few feathers within the BJP too with its rank and file questioning the timing and logic of the move.

Questions to the centre
Within the ruling party and the RSS, there was criticism of the move as it could directly affect government employees attending the events of the organisation, and because it could invite more public scrutiny especially via social media. The silence of top Ministers of the State on the issue has bolstered the belief that the withdrawal was due to pressure.

It is also understood that State BJP leaders have raised the matter with the party's central leadership. There are voices in the party that are asking if such a circular is in contravention of a 2024 order through which the Centre lifted a ban on government employees taking part in RSS activities.

Another view within the ruling establishment is that it was not a very well-thought out order. One of the top leader's interpretation was that it was issued to dissuade government employees from joining other political groups opposed to the ruling BJP or to check proselytisation which had been a raging issue. However, the decision was taken without calculating the impact it would have on the party and the RSS itself.

Against unionisation
In the context of Chhattisgarh, it is common knowledge that lower-level employees associate with semi-religious organisations or caste-based forums. Any attempts to prohibit the same can erode political support.

However, representatives of the employee organisations, on whom the restrictions would have applied had they not been lifted, have a different interpretation of the whole move. They say the scope of the ban as far as the language of the first circular was concerned was wide. They saw this as a move to prevent them from unionising and demanding welfare measures for themselves. Some of them even claim credit for the withdrawal.

Greater Chennai, northern T.N. may shape poll results

The Dravidian majors had pronounced successes in specific regions in recent elections

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy
Pon Vasanth B.A.

As Tamil Nadu braces for the results of its Assembly elections, the two Dravidian majors – the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) – are keeping their fingers crossed to see whose votes the debutant Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) eats into more.

A region-wise and margin-wise analysis of the last two elections, in 2016 and 2021, shows that the AIADMK, in the recently concluded voting for 2026, needs to not only retain its hold in the western region but also gain ground in the northern, central and Greater Chennai regions, which it had ceded to the DMK-led alliance in 2021, to get back to power. For this analysis, the parties have been grouped based on their alliances in 2026.

The 2016 Assembly election, which the AIADMK won, stands out as one of the most closely contested elections in Tamil Nadu in the past few decades. The AIADMK and the DMK won 89 seats each in the 178 seats in which they were facing each other.

In 2021, the north and Greater Chennai regions – which include the most urbanised areas of the State – tipped the scales heavily in favour of the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance (SPA). The Greater Chennai region consists of constituencies from Chennai, Kancheepuram, Chengalpattu and Tiruvallur districts. As shown in **Chart 2**, most of the gains of the SPA, which won a total of 159 seats, were concentrated in the central, southern and Greater Chennai regions. The central region includes constituencies from the Ariyalur, Karur, Mayiladuthurai, Nagapattinam, Perambalur, Pudukkottai, Thanjavur, Thiruvallur and Tiruchirappalli districts. The SPA

gained about 19 seats in the central region. This was followed by gains of 14 seats each in the Greater Chennai and southern regions. Interestingly, though the seats gained were more in the central region, the SPA's gains in terms of vote share were higher in the Greater Chennai region.

In the Greater Chennai region, the SPA secured over 55.1% of the votes, about 9 percentage points higher than what it had secured in 2016 (**Table 3**). In the northern region, the alliance secured over 49.4% of the votes, about 5 percentage points higher than in the previous election.

While the SPA gained 14 seats in the southern region, which includes constituencies from Dindigul, Kanniyakumari, Madurai, Ramanaathapuram, Sivaganga, Tenkasi, Theni, Thoothukudi, Tirunelveli and Virudhunagar, its gain in vote share was a negligible 0.3 percentage points.

The AIADMK-led alliance, however, retained its dominance in the western region in 2021 despite a small decline in its vote share. The National Democratic Alliance (NDA) won 41 of the 57 seats in the region, which comprises Coimbatore, Dharmapuri, Erode, Krishnagiri, Namakkal, Salem, The Nilgiris and Tiruppur. Its vote share in the region was 47.7%, nearly five percentage points lower than in 2016.

Data also indicates that the number of close contests came down overall. In 88 constituencies, the victory margins were within 5% in 2016 (**Chart 4**). This came down to 67 in 2021. The western region was an outlier, as the constituencies where victory margins were within 5% went up from 22 in 2016 to 25 in 2021.

The entry of actor Vijay's party is expected to throw up surprises. An intense battle between all three would lead to closer margins in more constituencies. Conversely, if the TVK competes with one of the two Dravidian majors for the runner-up spot, the winner may receive a larger share of the seats.

Battle for regions

Data for the charts were sourced from Lok Dhaba. The alliances for the analysis are based on current alliances



CHART 1: Regionwise split of constituencies

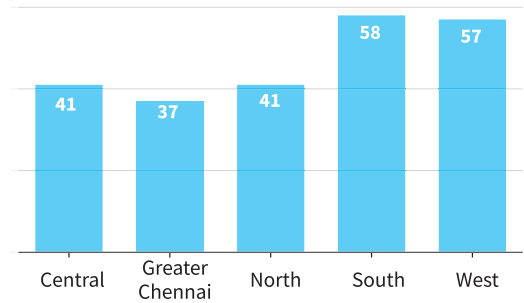


CHART 2: Seats secured by the SPA and AIADMK-led alliance in 2021, and change (in % points) when compared to 2016 polls

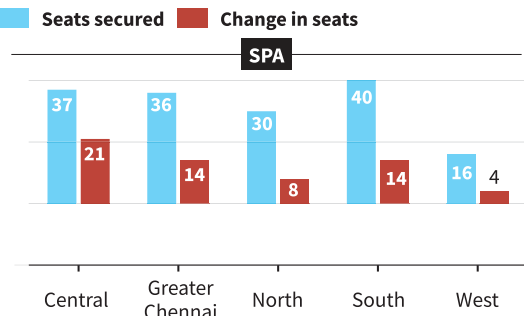


CHART 4: Margin and regionwise seats secured by the SPA and the NDA. Vote share margin: >5% <2% 2-5%

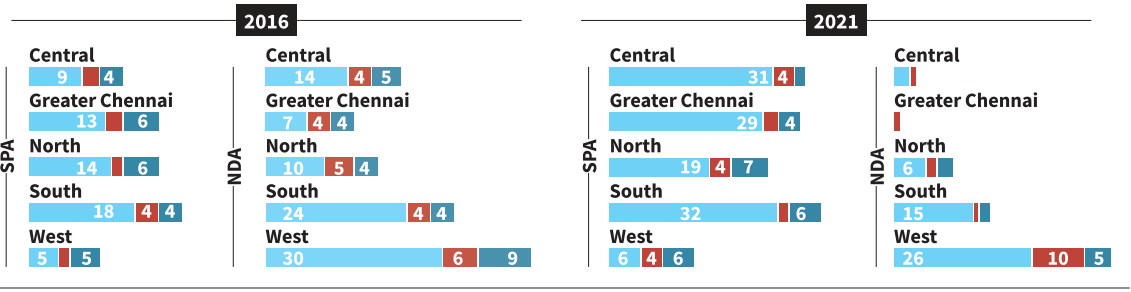


TABLE 3: The regionwise vote share secured in 2021 Assembly election, and change (in % points) when compared to 2016 polls

Region	SPA		NDA		NTK		Others	
	2021	↑↓	2021	↑↓	2021	↑↓	2021	↑↓
Central	50.1	4.7	40.2	-8.7	7	5.9	2.7	-1.9
Greater Chennai	55.1	9.1	34.4	-14.8	8.2	6.7	2.4	-0.9
North	49.4	4.6	43	-7	5.1	4.5	2.4	-2.3
South	46.2	0.3	42.4	-4.7	7.8	6.6	3.5	-2.3
West	44.6	1.8	47.7	-4.9	5.1	4.2	2.6	-1.1

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO APRIL 29, 1976

CIA activities: MPs' fears allayed

New Delhi, April 29: The Deputy Home Minister, Mr. F.H. Mohsin, to-day assured members who expressed concern in the Lok Sabha over the activities of CIA that the Government had taken serious notice of all that had been published in this regard. The Government was in no way less concerned about the security of the country than the members and the utmost vigilance was being maintained.

Mr. Mohsin who was replying to points made in a half-hour discussion raised by Mr. Bhogendra Jha (CPI) said what was being done by the Government was not a matter to be publicised. Mr. Jha and four other members – Mr. C.K. Chandrappan, Mr. Bamavatar Shastri and Mr. S. M. Banerjee (all CPI) and Mr. B.V. Naik (Congress) – referred to the disclosures of CIA activities made by the press and in a report of a committee of the United States Senate. They also sought to know whether the Government had gone into allegations of CIA links with some of the organisations in India. Mr. Mohsin said the Government had no information to prove CIA links with some of the organisations mentioned by members in the debate. However, the Government was vigilant not only about organisations mentioned in the discussion but there were many more organisations on which a watch was “necessary”.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO APRIL 29, 1926

Liquor smuggling in Canada

Ottawa, April 28: Sensational statements with regard to the alleged connection of high officials with smuggled liquor and motor-cars are made in a confidential report of Inspector Duncan to the Special Committee of the Commons, which is enquiring into this matter. Mr. Duncan asserts that investigations showed that large quantities of liquor were being shipped from the Government warehouses at Montreal to various officials at Ottawa, contrary to liquor laws, during the past three years.

The report also implicates a number of customs officers of Montreal in connections with the seizure of smuggled or stolen motor-cars, which Mr. Duncan alleges were secured for the private use of officials.

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Trinamool Congress supporters staging a protest against police observer Ajay Pal Sharma in Falta on Tuesday. PTI

According to the Election Commission, a “police observer is an IPS officer to monitor all activities related to force deployment, law and order situation and coordinate between

“The moment he shifted from that written, channelised report to publicly admonishing a candidate’s family before cameras, he crossed the line. An obser-

A police observer, speaking on condition of anonymity, said, "Observers are the eyes and ears of the EC. Any area domination plan or deployment at booths is done in their presence. They can move around for patrolling with Central forces but any complaint has to be acted upon by the local police and report sent to the EC."

Rahul meets Nicobarese community, promises to fight against infra project

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Hearty reception: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi being welcomed by a member of the Nicobarese community during his visit. PTI

He added that he had

“For the first time, tribal communities will have a direct opportunity to express their concerns, struggles, and aspirations to the Leader of Opposition. While Narendra Modi has chosen not to listen to their voices, decisions have

“We were also able to show him the maps marking our ancestral villages across the island,” one leader said, adding that Mr. Gandhi assured them of raising their issues in Parliament as well.

BJD seeks 'urgent, decisive' EC intervention on its Rajya Sabha polling complaint

A portrait of a man with dark hair and glasses, wearing a white shirt and a green scarf. He is looking directly at the camera. In the background, other people are visible, suggesting a public event or gathering.

Sasmit Patra

been marked, is *ex facie* contrary to the Conduct of Election Rules, 1961, which permit issuance of a replacement ballot only upon strict compliance with the 'spoilt ballot' procedure. The deviation from the prescribed statutory procedure is not merely technical but goes to the root of the election.

“The objections and submissions were officially videographed and photographed by the commission’s designated personnel, forming part of the official record. Despite this, and despite the prior complaints submitted during polling and escalation by the party president, no response, clarification, or action taken report has been communicated till date,” he said.

Nishant's yatra will decide politics of Bihar: JD(U)

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Mr. Kushwaha, Leader of the JD(U) Legislature Party Shrawon Kumar and other party functionaries will take part in the yatra.

Hold all-party meet to build consensus on implementing women's quota, says Cong.

He alleged that the go-



Jairam Ramesh

“An all-party meeting should be convened to discuss how the Nari Shakti

He further contended that women's reservation "was never the issue" during the Special Session of Parliament, maintaining that the government's primary objective had been delimitation. "It is now time for the Prime Minister to make amends for his sins of using India's women to drive through his personal political agenda and to instead deliver justice to them," Mr. Ramesh said.

Team stopped from visiting Ghazipur girl's family: Cong.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

While the girl's family has alleged sexual assault and murder, the police have registered a case but said the post-mortem suggested drowning, with preliminary findings indicating a possible suicide.

Sikkim's natural farming is a model for the entire country, says Prime Minister

Lighter moment: Prime Minister Narendra Modi playing football with youth in Gangtok on Tuesday. ANI

"Sikkim has about 500 bird and 700 butterfly species. It has a rich forest cover, while the majestic Kanchenjunga is a tourist attraction. Nature has blessed Sikkim, which is why people want to visit the State time and again," the Prime Minister said, noting the impact of tou-

He cited a National Highway and the Svoke-Rangpo railway projects as examples of the Bharatiya Janata Party-led Centre's focus on improving connectivity and infrastructure to boost tourism in Sikkim. At the same time, he slammed the Congress for allegedly ignoring Sikkim and other northeastern States whenever it was in power at the Centre.

"Things which the BJP

“For us, the Northeast is not just an important part of the country, but also Bharat’s *Ashtalakshmi*. That’s why we have resolved to ‘Act Fast’ after working on the ‘Act East’ policy,” he said.

Modi slams Opposition over women's quota, unveils key projects in Varanasi

“These dynastic parties are unwilling to permit the daughters of our nation to reach the Assembly and Parliament. They are aware that if the daughters who are active in the community ascend to leadership positions, they will lose their grip on power. Their authority will be challenged. This is the rea-



Special visit: Women arriving to attend a meeting addressed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in Varanasi on Tuesday. AFP

He noted that “new op-

In Varanasi, he inaugu-

Mr. Modi reached Varanasi in the afternoon and was received by Governor Anandiben Patel, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, several Ministers and senior BJP leaders.

Business

INBRIEF



Rupee falls 53 paise to close at 94.68 against U.S. dollar

The rupee depreciated 53 paise to close at 94.68 against the U.S. dollar on Tuesday, as elevated crude oil prices and unabated foreign capital outflows amid rising geopolitical uncertainties dented investor sentiments. At the interbank forex market, the rupee opened at 94.35 against the U.S. dollar, then lost ground and settled for the day at 94.68, registering a fall of 53 paise over its previous close. On Monday, the rupee closed at 94.15 against the U.S. dollar.

No proposal to increase price of petrol after State polls

There is no proposal to increase petrol prices once the State elections conclude, said Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary at the Petroleum Ministry. “After April 1, I must inform that there is no proposal for increase in petrol prices,” Ms. Sharma told reporters at an inter-ministerial press conference on the West Asia situation. The government had last increased the price of a certain premium variant of petrol, namely, XP95, Power95 and Speed, on the mentioned date.

Working group formed to study impact of scrap supplies

A working group has been formed to study the impact on supplies of aluminium scrap amid the escalating tensions in West Asia and to suggest recommendations, Piyush Goyal, Secretary at the Ministry of Mines, told reporters here on Tuesday. Escalating tensions in West Asia have contributed to a spike in prices of imported scrap with secondary aluminium producers seeking a relaxation in import duties. India levies a 2.5% import duty on import of aluminium scrap.

‘Temasek, Canada’s fund eye stake sale in NSE IPO’

Reuters
MUMBAI

Singapore’s State-owned investor Temasek and the Canada Pension Plan Investment Board are among 20 investors looking to sell stakes when National Stock Exchange (NSE) goes public this year, sources said.

Maruti Q4 net slips 7% on metal prices

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

India’s biggest car maker Maruti Suzuki India Ltd. reported fourth quarter net profit slid 7% year-on-year to ₹3,590 crore on account of a steep rise in commodity prices [metal costs have risen 2%] and mark-to-market losses on debt instrument investments, chairman R.C. Bhargava said. Sales income at ₹50,079

crore grew 29%. In Q4, the firm recorded its highest-ever quarterly sales of 6,76,209 units, up 11.8%. Domestic sales stood at 538,994 units and exports at an all-time high of 137,215 units. The board recommended a dividend of ₹140 per share for the year compared with ₹135 per share in previous year. For the full year, net profit grew by only 1% to ₹14,445 crore.

Annual sales income grew 20% to ₹1,74,370 crore. “This performance was made possible because of a steep growth in the local market in the second half of the year owing to GST reduction,” he said. Sales were restricted by a limitation in output capacity as evidenced by about 1,90,000 pending orders at year end. In addition, the dealer inventory was at a low of

about 12 days’ stock. For the full year, the firm achieved a record total sales of 2,422,713 units. He said the war in West Asia has had minimal impact on the car market in India on high demand from Indian customers. “Nothing much adverse impact is happening here. This year, the firm is making a capital investment of ₹14,000 crore to add capacity,” he said.

Nayara Energy likely to restart mid-May

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Nayara Energy’s Vadinar refinery in Gujarat, which closed for maintenance on April 9, is expected to recommence operations somewhere in the middle of May, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary at the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas told reporters here.

Amid the West Asia tensions, India has increased domestic production of the largely imported cooking gas to about 46,000 tons a day. While Nayara Energy’s domestic supply of LPG is marginal, the Vadinar refinery’s return to operations after the planned maintenance is expected to relieve strained supplies.

TMB Q4 net surges 28%, to pay ₹12.50 final dividend

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamilnad Mercantile Bank (TMB) reported a 28% year on year growth in net profit for the quarter ended March 31 to ₹374 crore. The board recommended the payment of final dividend of ₹12.50 per equity share.

‘PLI plan warps 2W market, junks innovation-led firms’

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

A new report says the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme for two-wheelers has distorted the auto market by driving growth while sidelining innovation-led manufacturers, even as the Centre argues that many such startups lack the capital and market access to scale. Non-PLI entities’ sales growth rate slid from 407% in FY22 to -33% in FY24 and -41% in FY25. This shift coincided with a reordering of market leadership, at the expense of the industry’s innovation engine, says the Centre for Digital Economy Policy Research in its report titled “Impact assessment of auto PLI on two-wheeler EV industry”.

Outside PLI framework On innovation, the report highlights much of the patent activity and new product development has come from firms outside the PLI framework. Many PLI beneficiaries avoided hard-to-electrify segments like electric motorcycles.



The PLI scheme aimed to boost local manufacturing.

In contrast, non-PLI firms are leading development in high-performance and electric motorcycle platforms, but face funding constraints and lack of production-linked support, limiting their ability to scale, states the report. However, a senior government official said there was no proposal to unveil a separate PLI scheme for startups in the automotive sector. “Ministry of MSMEs has many policies [for such startups]. But they lack capital, market access and R&D,” the official stated. The report comes amid demands from players like Ather Energy which said

the PLI scheme must include specialised EV manufacturers, arguing the current high revenue thresholds and rigid criteria favour legacy automakers and exclude pure-EV startups. Launched in 2021, the auto PLI scheme aims to boost local manufacturing, cut imports, and position India as a global hub for future mobility. It focuses on Advanced Automotive Technology products such as electric vehicles, hydrogen fuel cell vehicles, and key components like advanced batteries and power electronics. The government has set an overall investment target of about ₹42,500 crore for the auto sector under the PLI scheme. Eligibility criteria for vehicle makers require a minimum global revenue of ₹10,000 crore and a commitment to invest at least ₹3,000 crore in India. Sops under the scheme are linked to incremental sales over a defined base year. Firms must also reach at least 50% domestic value addition to qualify.

Monitoring cell set up by Textile Ministry

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

The Textile Ministry has set up a monitoring cell to examine ways to support the industry, especially man-made fibre sector, impacted by the West Asia crisis. The Ministry is holding weekly meetings with export promotion councils, domestic industry associations, regional clusters and State government officials, as per a press statement. GAIL has indicated that both the textiles and handicraft sectors have been prioritised with supplies maintained at 80% of the past six months’ average consumption. This follows the Textiles Ministry’s request to the Centre seeking assured supply of natural gas to these sectors. The Ministry took up lifting Customs Duty with the Revenue Department on manmade fibre inputs while battling for removal/deferment of anti-dumping levy on elastomeric filament yarn and viscose rayon filament yarn.

Crude oil imports slip by 2 MT over Jan.; 50% more costly

Amid the ongoing West Asia conflict, India paid ₹1.2 lakh crore for the March imports as opposed to ₹86,000 crore in January, representing a 40% increase overall, PPAC data showed

M. Kalyanaraman
CHENNAI

In a reflection of the impact of the West Asia war that started end of February, India’s crude oil imports dipped to some 19 million tonnes in March, down by 2 million tonnes from January and 1 million from the shorter month of February. March imports were the lowest since July 2025. India paid ₹1.2 lakh crore for the March imports as opposed to ₹86,000 crore in January, representing a 40% increase overall, data from the Petroleum Planning & Analysis Cell (PPAC) showed. In terms of the price India has paid for unit imports, this is an increase of more than 50%. Indigenous crude oil production was 2.17 million tonnes, same as January. India is the world’s third-biggest oil importer and consumer. Compared



Quick fix: The Centre had ordered ramping up of LPG production early March to compensate for the fall in imports. NAGARA GOPAL

with March 2025, India’s imports fell by almost 17% and imports of crude oil products declined by some 30%. At nearly 1.4 million tonnes, domestic LPG production was up by 20% compared with January and 30% increase compared with February. The government had ordered a ramping up of LPG production early March to compensate for the fall in imports as a consequence

of the West Asia war. First, a 25% increase was claimed. Refineries were directed to maximise LPG output by diverting petrochemical streams. Then a 30% increase was claimed by government by mid-March, then 40% by late March. In March, LPG imports fell from nearly 2.2 million tonnes in January to some 0.82 million, representing a decrease of more than 62%. The March Snapshot,

published a few days ago, revealed that there was a pullback of nearly 8% in household LPG supply, nearly 50% reduction in non-household LPG supply, and 75% in bulk LPG supply compared with March 2025. In March, the Indian government set in motion a process to bring back Indian-flagged LPG carriers stuck in the Persian Gulf region due to U.S.-Israel war on Iran. Four LPG carriers were brought back and reached India in March. They were carrying some 1.8 lakh tonnes of LPG. The LPG import shortfall is estimated to be narrower in April. Meanwhile, India has contracted with many foreign ships to bring in LPG from the U.S. in May. Some of the Indian-flagged LPG ships that had been lying idle after unloading, may well be leaving for U.S. ports for loading, if surplus LPG was available there.

‘Airlines at shutdown risk amid fuel price shock’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Federation of Indian Airlines (FIA), which represents Air India, IndiGo and SpiceJet, has warned that the sector is under “extreme stress”, with some airlines on the “verge of shutting down”, and has

sought urgent relief on fuel pricing ahead of the next monthly revision on May 1. The industry body has proposed a “crack band” pricing mechanism similar to the one introduced during COVID-19, under which oil marketing companies (OMCs) would still recover higher crude costs along

with reasonable refining margins. The “crack spread”, or the margins oil companies earn for refining crude into jet fuel, has surged dramatically from \$11-18 per barrel earlier to over \$130 per barrel now, driving ATF prices far above crude oil trends that rose from \$72 per barrel to

\$118, the letter stated. While on April 1 the government tried to provide some relief to airlines by ensuring only a 25% increase in ATF price for domestic flights, the FIA says international services have become “impractical” due to which there were “significant losses”.

A.P. eyes second mega data centre in Vizag with Reliance as key partner

Sambasiva Rao M.
AMARAVATI

The Andhra Pradesh government is moving ahead with its plans to position Visakhapatnam as a major data infrastructure hub, with another large-scale data centre project in the pipeline involving Reliance Industries. On Tuesday, Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu laid the foundation stone for a 1 GW Google hyperscale AI data centre in Visakhapatnam. The project, estimated at around \$15 billion (₹1.35 lakh crore), is being developed as a joint venture involving AdaniConnex, Google Cloud, and Airtel Nxtra.

Another project Parallely, as per sources in the government, the State government is in the final stages of firming up another major data centre project of 1.5 GW in the same city, with Reliance expected to be the principal partner. According to sources, discussions for this project began earlier, with the Andhra Pradesh Economic Development Board confirming in November 2025 that negotiations were underway with Digital Connexion—a consortium comprising Reliance Industries, Brookfield, and Digital Realty. The proposed Reliance-backed facility is expected to attract investments ex-

The proposed Reliance-backed facility is expected to attract investments over ₹1.6 lakh crore

ceeding ₹1.6 lakh crore. Highly placed sources in the Secretariat in Amaravati indicated that a memorandum of understanding (MoU) had already been signed with the APEDB, signalling steady progress toward project finalisation. Sources also said that RIL had asked for about 900 acres of land.

Official announcement Sources also said that the government was likely to officially announce the development in the second or third week of May.

Officials said that the upcoming data centre complex would be built to global standards, incorporating high-density AI-ready racks, dedicated power substations, and redundant power supply systems. It is also expected to feature robust connectivity infrastructure to cater to hyperscalers, enterprise clients, cloud service providers, and emerging artificial intelligence workloads. With back-to-back mega investments, Andhra Pradesh is aiming to transform Visakhapatnam into a leading destination for next-generation digital infrastructure and AI-driven industries.

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LONDON

U.K. PM's former top aide says sorry over appointment of Mandelson



Morgan McSweeney, former Chief of Staff to U.K. Prime Minister Keir Starmer, said on Tuesday that he made a “a serious mistake” by recommending Peter Mandelson, a scandal-tainted friend of Jeffrey Epstein, be made British Ambassador to the U.S., but denied pressuring officials to ignore security concerns. AP

WASHINGTON

Trump hails British as ‘friends’ as King Charles begins U.S. state tour



U.S. President Donald Trump said the U.S. has “no closer friends” than the British, as he welcomed King Charles III to the White House on a state visit overshadowed by tensions over the Iran war. King Charles will address the U.S. Congress and is expected to call in his speech for “reconciliation and renewal” amid strains in ties. AFP

MEXICO CITY

Mexico captures top cartel leader in blow to Jalisco crime syndicate



Mexican authorities announced the capture of two top criminals, one of them a close ally of Nemesio “El Mencho” Oseguera, the slain founder of the Jalisco New Generation Cartel and his potential successor. Audias Flores Silva, nicknamed “The Gardener” (El Jardinero), was seen as one of the possible successors. AFP

DHAKA

Bangladesh starts fuelling its first nuclear plant in landmark move



Bangladesh has begun loading uranium fuel into its first nuclear power station on Tuesday, a key step towards bringing the 2,400 MW plant online to ease pressure on the overstretched power grid. The Rooppur nuclear plant, built with loans from Russia, could meet 10% of the power demands of the South Asian nation. AFP

Seven killed, dozens wounded after Pakistani strikes in Afghan province

Taliban officials say missiles struck civilian facilities which Pakistan dismissed as a ‘blatant lie’; the attack was the first violent incident since peace talks earlier this month; Islamabad accuses Taliban regime of sheltering militants which Kabul denies

Associated Press
KABUL

Mortars and missiles fired from Pakistan on Monday struck a university and civilian homes in north-eastern Afghanistan, killing seven people and wounding at least 85, Taliban officials said.

Pakistan denied the accusation of targeting a university.

The strikes were the first violent incident since Chinese-mediated peace talks between the two sides earlier this month.

Both countries had been embroiled in months of deadly fighting that has killed hundreds of people



Toll of truce: An Afghan boy receives medical treatment after being injured in Pakistani shelling in Asadabad on Tuesday. AFP

since late February, when Afghanistan launched a cross-border attack on Pakistan in retaliation for air strikes inside Afghanistan.

Afghan deputy government spokesman Hamdullah Fitrat said Monday’s at-

tack took place in Asadabad, the capital of Kunar Province, as well as various areas in another district in the province.

‘War crime’
Authorities said the death

toll stood at seven, with 85 people wounded.

Mr. Fitrat said the wounded included women, children and students at the Sayed Jama-luddin Afghan University, and described the attacks as “an unforgivable war crime, barbarity, and provocative act.”

Afghanistan’s Ministry of Higher Education said about 30 students and professors were injured in the strike on the university, which it said had caused extensive damage to the facility.

In a statement, Pakistan’s Information Ministry said that “Pakistan’s targeting is precise and intelligence based. No strike has

been carried out on the said university. The claims are frivolous and fake.”

Afghan and Pakistani officials met in Urumqi, China in early April, and had agreed not to escalate their conflict and “explore a comprehensive solution,” Beijing had said after mediating the talks.

On Saturday, Afghan Foreign Minister Amir Khan Mutaqi described the recent negotiations in China as “positive.”

Pakistan accuses Afghanistan of harbouring militants that carry out deadly attacks inside Pakistan, especially the Pakistani Taliban, known as Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan. Kabul denies the charge.

Israel using water access as a weapon in Gaza: MSF report

Agence France-Presse
GENEVA

Israeli authorities are systematically depriving people in Gaza of the water they need to live, Doctors Without Borders warned on Tuesday, decrying a campaign of “collective punishment” against Palestinians.

The extensive destruction of civilian water infrastructure in Gaza coupled with obstruction of access constitutes “an integral part of Israel’s genocide”, said the medical charity, which goes by its French acronym MSF.

In a report entitled “Water as a Weapon”, MSF said the “engineered scarcity” was occurring alongside “direct killing of civilians, the devastation of health facilities, (and) the destruction of homes”.

Together, this amount-



Parched souls: Displaced Palestinian children wait to refill canisters with water at a refugee camp in the central Gaza Strip. AFP

ed to “the deliberate infliction of destructive and inhumane conditions of life on the Palestinian population in Gaza”, warned the report, based on testimonies and data MSF collected in 2024 and 2025.

“Israeli authorities know that without water, life ends,” MSF emergency manager Claire San Filippo said in a statement.

“Yet they have deliber-

ately and systematically obliterated water infrastructure in Gaza, whilst consistently blocking water-related supplies from entering.”

The report, which was slammed by Israel, pointed to data from the UN, EU and World Bank indicating that Israel had destroyed or damaged nearly 90% of water and sanitation infrastructure in Gaza.

Explosions rock capital Kyiv, six killed in Russia, Ukraine

Agence France-Presse
KYIV

Explosions echoed over Kyiv on Tuesday during a rare daytime Russian drone attack on the capital, after the two sides launched strikes that left six dead.

A major oil refinery in southern Russia was set ablaze, triggering a local state of emergency as thick black smoke billowed over the coastal town of Tuapse.

Russia has pummelled Ukrainian cities mainly by launching long-range aerial barrages at night.

Kyiv officials announced that air defence systems were operating against Russian drones flying over the city and that two people were hurt in the attack.

Ukrainian authorities meanwhile said two peo-

Ukraine’s interceptor systems shot down more than 33,000 Russian drones in March, says Minister

ple were killed in the central Dnipropetrovsk region and in the eastern Kharkiv region.

A Ukrainian drone attack earlier killed three people in the Russian border region of Belgorod and one more in the neighbouring Bryansk region.

Kyiv confirmed its forces had targeted oil facilities in Tuapse. “This production is involved in supplying Russia’s Army in Ukraine,” it said.

Footage published online by the Krasnodar regional governor showed fire and thick smoke at the

site of the Tuapse oil refinery.

Kyiv and Moscow have stepped up their aerial attacks over recent months, with both sides mainly targeting energy infrastructure.

The Russian Defence Ministry said on Tuesday its air defences overnight intercepted 186 Ukrainian drones over Russian regions, the annexed Crimea and the Black and the Azov seas.

Ukraine’s Defense Minister Mykhailo Fedorov said the country’s interceptor systems shot down more than 33,000 Russian drones of various types in March, a record monthly figure since Moscow invaded the country more than four years ago.

(With inputs from Associated Press)

Iraq appoints newcomer as next PM amid U.S. pressure

Agence France-Presse
BAGHDAD

Iraq’s newly-elected President Nizar Amode nominated businessman and political newcomer Ali al-Zaidi as Prime Minister-designate on Monday, after the country’s leaders yielded to U.S. pressure not to support the bid of a former premier close to Iran.

The Coordination Framework, an alliance of Shia factions, had initially backed Nouri al-Maliki but an ultimatum by U.S. President Donald Trump left Iraqi leaders looking elsewhere.

Mr. Zaidi has 30 days to form a government – a daunting task in a country where constitutional deadlines are rarely respected.

‘Just peace’ can’t be achieved through organisations seeking ‘fees’: Baerbock

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

“Just peace” cannot be achieved by seeking membership in organisations that charge a joining “fee”, said Annalena Baerbock, President of the 80th Session of the UN General Assembly on Tuesday in response to a question on the Board of Peace for Gaza Strip established by U.S. President Donald Trump.

Speaking to journalists here, Ms. Baerbock cautioned against “unilateral use of force” while arguing that member states of the UN can mobilise themselves for an institutional action against a state that is



Annalena Baerbock

accused of genocide by bringing the matter to the UN Security Council.

“Because every country, no matter how big or small, how powerful or rich has a seat at the table, because you will not find just peace for anybody in the world if you have to

pay the fee to join it. We are witnessing growing geopolitical tensions, increasing fragmentation, and pressure on the three pillars of the UN – peace and security, development, and human rights”.

The Board of Peace has 28 countries as the ‘founding members’ of the group that is tasked with stopping the war in Gaza where Israel has been carrying out a military campaign following the October 7, 2023 attack by Hamas. A draft concept note of the board had mentioned that members would have to pay \$1billion to be part of the group.

Responding to a question from *The Hindu* on the

U.S. targeting and kidnapping President Nicolas Maduro of Venezuela, Ms. Baerbock said “use of force is prohibited by the Charter.” She said that every person is supposed to enjoy human rights and if those rights are endangered then member states are supposed to follow the process mentioned in the Charter.

“Unilateral action is a violation of the UN Charter. Because the Charter is not optional. It is an obligation for every member state to protect peace and security around the world and protect sovereignty of every member,” said Ms. Baerbock.

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Rohit undergoes fitness drills, skips nets session on match eve



Kohli is the greatest batter the IPL has ever seen: McClenaghan



Dominant East Bengal makes short work of Odisha in the ISL



Kothari masters Advani to retain IBSF World billiards crown



Ferreira and Shubham combine to end Punjab Kings' unbeaten streak

Abhishek plans meticulously: Franklin

Indian women lose to China, crash out

I didn't want to quit: Barwal on pushing through till the finish

[illegible]

INBRIEF



Kothari to defend World billiards title against Advani

For the second straight year, the final of the IBSF World billiards championship will be an all-Indian affair with champion Sourav Kothari taking on Pankaj Advani. In the semifinals at Carlow (Ireland) on Tuesday, Advani outclassed England's Robert Hall 1184-420 to make his ninth straight final, while Kothari rallied to score a 633-443 victory over compatriot Dhvaj Haria.

Quarterfinal results: Advani bt Martin Goodwill (Eng) 755-356; Hall bt Siddharth Parikh 425-408; Haria bt S. Shrikrishna 459-376; Kothari bt David Causier (Eng) 757-498.

Indian table tennis team gets ₹90 lakh support

The Sports Authority of India put in place a comprehensive support worth over ₹90 lakh to ensure the Indian table tennis team put its best foot forward at the milestone centenary International Table Tennis Federation (ITTF) World Team Table Tennis Championships (WTTC), which got underway in London on Tuesday. The event is scheduled until May 10 at the OVO Arena in Wembley.

PM inaugurates six BCCI indoor cricket academies

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday inaugurated six state-of-the-art indoor cricket academies across northeast India, which are part of the BCCI's expansion programme for infrastructure in the region. The academies are located in Rangpo (Sikkim), Doimukh (Arunachal Pradesh), Imphal (Manipur), Madan Kurkalang (Meghalaya), Aizawl (Mizoram), and Dimapur (Nagaland). The inauguration ceremony was attended by ICC chairman Jay Shah along with all the office-bearers of BCCI while administrators from the other five northeastern states joined via video conference.

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA II Division Multi-Day League, II-A, India Pistons vs Pristine (Wahe Guru-A); Egmore RC vs Coromandel (TI-Murugappa), 9 a.m.; II-B: UFCC (T. Nagar) vs Bunts (AM Jain); Crombest vs Komaleeswarar (SRMC, turf); Swaraj vs Indian Bank (Venkateswara), 9 a.m.; Friends inter-academy under-12 tournament, 1 p.m., N.M. Greens.

Meet Rithika Sri, the first transgender umpire from TN

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Cricket Association recently called out for applicants to appear for the State Panel Umpire exams. For the first time, the application form allowed a person to select 'Other' in the gender category, in addition to Male and Female. While it may look like a small change, it came thanks to the sheer grit and determination of a 31-year-old umpire from Coimbatore.

R. Rithika Sri is a transwoman from Salem who has been umpiring in the Salem and Coimbatore circuit since 2021 and has been instrumental in forcing this through.

Rithika is the first transgender umpire in Tamil Nadu. Born as R. Muthuraj, she is a diploma holder in Mechanical Engineering. The engineering dropout was working in Mohali at a call centre when she caught the umpiring bug while watching the IPL.

When the COVID-19 pandemic hit and forced her to return to her hometown, Rithika decided to become an umpire.

"I contacted the Salem District Cricket Association through social media. U. Jayaraman, the umpire committee chairman, played a key role in guiding me. I also have to credit two senior umpires, R. Parthasarathy and V. Santhi



Rithika Sri has been umpiring since 2021.

Booshan," Rithika told *The Hindu*.

"She rose through the ranks to become one of the best in our district," said Jayaraman, who is also a psychometric assessor.

It was around this time that Rithika was contemplating a gender transition. "Jayaraman sir and his wife supported me. Then, he advised me to establish myself as an umpire for a few years before transitioning. They were worried I would face discrimination otherwise," she added.

After deciding to undergo transition in Coimbatore in 2024, Rithika shifted to the CDCA league.

"The first time in Coimbatore, I went to watch because they wanted me to get familiar with the new district, but I was denied entry, and there were hurtful comments. I went back home crying after an hour, but not before fighting

Atletico and Arsenal seek redemption in semifinals

Neither team has won the European title yet; Simeone's men have to dust off the Copa del Rey final loss whereas Arteta & Co. need to shift focus from the tight Premier League title race

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Agence France-Presse
MADRID

Atletico Madrid and Diego Simeone have regularly tasted the sting of disappointment, even in what is the club's golden age.

It hosts Arsenal on Wednesday in the Champions League semifinals, chasing redemption after its crushing Copa del Rey final defeat little over a week ago.

Tens of thousands of Atletico fans travelled down to Seville only to go home empty-handed, just as it did in the 2014 and 2016 Champions League finals against bitter rival Real Madrid.

Atletico has never won Europe's premier competition, also beaten in its other final appearance in 1974.

It can take a first step towards a fourth final against Mikel Arteta's side this week.

In its first game back home after the Copa final disappointment, on Satur-



Gunners test awaits: Atletico will have high expectations from Griezmann. REUTERS

day against Athletic Bilbao, Atletico's fans gave the team a cold reception.

"The fans don't need messages (from me), what they need is to win," noted Simeone, Atletico's most decorated manager, in Seville.

The Arsenal tie offers a route to immediate atonement, and by Wednesday, the atmosphere will be frenzied, intoxicating, as it

was for the quarterfinal elimination of Barcelona.

Atletico is no longer at the Vicente Calderon, but the Metropolitan stadium is just as intense, louder still, with the increased capacity.

The Rojiblancos' support is the loudest in Spain and Simeone called on them to give his team the edge against the Premier League leader.

Bernadette Szocs emerges the biggest buy at UTT Season 7 player auction

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

Big names commanded bigger bids as franchises zeroed in on proven performers and emerging Indian talent at the Butterfly Ultimate Table Tennis Season 7 player auction on Tuesday, with Bernadette Szocs topping the charts.

UTT auctions are based on tokens as notional value, with players signing contracts with the league promoters for undisclosed amount.



Szocs. FILE PHOTO: VIJAY SONEJI

The event will be held in Panaji from July 9 to 26.

The squads: Ahmedabad APL Pipers: Adrien Rassenfosse (20,00,000 tokens), Sanil Shetty (3,20,000), Payas Jain (16,80,000), Sofia Polcanova (27,20,000), Manika Batra (27,00,000), Kavya Bhatt (32,00,000).

Dabang Delhi T.T.C.: Youssef Abdelaziz (12,00,000), G. Sathiyan (27,00,000), Raegan Albuquerque (3,00,000), Maria Xiao (27,20,000), Divyanshi Bhowmick (10,40,000), Sutirtha Mukherjee (8,00,000).

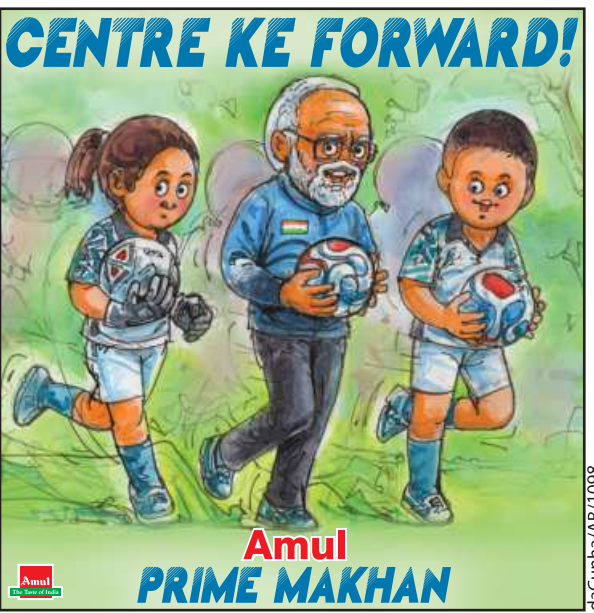
Dempo Goa Challengers: Alvaro Robles (22,80,000), Divyansh Srivastava (3,00,000), P.B. Abhinandh (3,00,000), Bernadette Szocs (40,00,000), Syndrela Das (17,00,000), Ananya Chande (3,00,000).

Kolkata ThunderBlades: Eduard Ionescu (24,20,000), Ankur Bhattacharjee (9,45,000), Jeet Chandra (7,00,000), Zeng Jian (20,00,000), Taneesha Kotecha (3,00,000), Ayhika Mukherjee (20,20,000).

PBG Pune Jaguars: Omar Assar (20,00,000), Snehit SFR (12,00,000), Mudit Dani (3,00,000), Prithika Pavade (24,80,000), Diya Chitale (37,40,000), Sayanika Maji (3,00,000).

U Mumba TT: Lilian Bardet (21,40,000), Akash Pal (9,45,000), Manush Shah (37,20,000), Anna Hursey (22,20,000), Nithyashree Mani (3,00,000), Anusha Kutumbale (3,00,000).

UP Prometheans: Ricardo Walther (12,00,000), Sudhanshu Grover (3,20,000), Manav Thakkar (36,00,000), Yangzi Liu (32,00,000), Sayali Wani (9,00,000), Swastika Ghosh (7,00,000).



Satyajit, Harschit hog the limelight



On a roll: Satyajit clinched the floor exercise and vault titles in the senior section. BISWARANJAN ROUT

GYMNASTICS

Sports Bureau

Satyajit Mondal clinched the floor exercise and vault titles in the senior division men's apparatus finals of the National artistic gymnastics championships in Bhubaneswar on Tuesday.

Harschit Damodaran also shone in junior division by claiming gold medals in floor exercise, rings, vault and horizontal bar.

The results: Men: Senior: Floor exercise: 1. Satyajit Mondal (RSPB) 12.700 (higher e-score), 2. Sahil Yadav (Har) 12.700, 3. Niladri Sarkar (RSPB) 12.367; **Pommel horse:** 1. Siddharth Verma (RSPB) 13.067, 2. Sohom Majumder (WB) 12.800 (higher e-score), 3. S. Harikrishnan (SSCB) 12.800; **Rings:** 1. Adari Navin Sai Krishna (Cht) 13.067, 2. K.P. Swathish (RSPB) 13.000, 3. Omkar Shinde (Mah) 12.533; **Vault:** 1. Satyajit Mondal (RSPB)

13.450, 2. Uday Naidu (Kar) 13.117, 3. Tapeswarnath Das (SSCB) 13.050; **Parallel bars:** 1. Gaurav Kumar (SSCB) 12.833, 2. Abhijeet Kumar (UP) 12.567, 3. Siddhant P. Konde (RSPB) 12.400; **Horizontal bar:** 1. Shayan Sharma (RSPB) 13.100, 2. Shreyas Chaudhari (SSCB) 11.767, 3. Tousif Rana Mondal (RSPB) 11.367. **Junior: Floor exercise:** 1. Harschit Damodaran (UP) 12.767, 2. Sk. Nabigh Ali (WB) 12.333, 3. Nishad Narvane (Mah) 12.033; **Pommel horse:** 1. Swarnim Jaiswal (MP) 12.467, 2. Sk. Nabigh Ali (WB) 12.167, 3. Prasun Amalnerkar (Mah) 11.933; **Rings:** 1. Harschit Damodaran (UP) 11.833, 2. Nishad Narvane (Mah) 11.800, 3. Suman Dutta (WB) 11.633; **Vault:** 1. Harschit Damodaran (UP) 13.617, 2. Akshat Bajaj (Del) 12.867, 3. Sohag Sagar Atre (UP) 12.400; **Parallel bars:** 1. Nishad Narvane (Mah) 12.367, 2. Tulin Tewary (Jha) 12.233, 3. Aaroh Sharma (Del) 12.200; **Horizontal bar:** 1. Harschit Damodaran (UP) 12.500, 2. Mod. Zaid Ansari (UP) 12.967, 3. Ishan (Har) 1.900.

United close in on a CL spot

Reuters
MANCHESTER

Manchester United's Casemiro and Benjamin Sesko struck first-half goals to secure a 2-1 Premier League home win over Brentford on Monday and take their side to the brink of Cham-

pions League football for the first time since the 2023-24 season.

United is now 12 points behind Arsenal and nine adrift of second-placed Manchester City.

The results: Premier League: Manchester

United 2 (Casemiro 11, Sesko 43) bt Brentford 1 (Jensen 87).

Serie A: Cagliari 3 (Mendy 1, 8, Borelli 47) bt Atalanta 2 (Scamacca 40, 45).

Lazio 3 (Pellegrini 50, Pedro 80, Maldini 90+5) drew with Udinese 3 (Ehizibue 18, Atta 86, 90+3).

LaLiga: Espanyol 0 drew with Levante 0.

TNCA MULTI-DAY



Pranesh (India Pistons, 4/43 incl. a hat-trick); Akshath (India Pistons, 155); Javed (India Pistons, 104); Mithun (UFCC, T. Nagar, 113); Jaisimha (Egmore RC, 106); Abhinav (Egmore RC, 5/62); Surya (MCC, 152).

Akshath, Javed and Pranesh excel

C.P. Akshath (155) and R. Javed Mohammed (104) starred with the bat, while M. Pranesh claimed four for 43, including a hat-trick, as India Pistons posted a 208-run victory over Coromandel SC in a Group-A fixture of TNCA second division multi-day tournament at the TI-Murugappa ground recently.

In another match at Tagore, J. Jaisimha's 106 and Arjun S. Nair's unbeaten 79 set up Egmore RC's four-wicket win over MCC. Earlier, leg-spinner M. Abhinav claimed five for 62. In a Group-B match at the PBEL ground, V. Mithun Vijay's 113 guided UFCC (T. Nagar) to a seven-wicket



Mannayay (Indian Bank, 105); Vineeth (Crombest, 103 n.o.).

victory over Indian Bank. V.K. Vineeth's unbeaten 103 powered Crombest to a six-wicket win over Swaraj at Venkateswara grounds.

The scores: Group-A: At TI-Murugappa: India Pistons 486/7 in 90 overs (N. Sabarinath 32, C.P. Akshath 155, S.T. Shri Dharun 65, R. Javed Mohammed 104, S.L. Lawrence Nova 48, Mohit Panghal 4/74) bt Coromandel 278 in 69 overs (Siddharth Prakash 80, P. Hemcharan 98, S.J. Abu Shajith 54 n.o., M. Pranesh 4/43). **At Tagore:** MCC 368 in 86.4 overs (A.K. Rajagopalan 78, G. Surya

Kanth 152, S. Dinesh Raj 69, K.M. Sharan 36, D. Pranavkumar 3/38, M. Abhinav 5/62) lost to Egmore RC 372/6 in 84.1 overs (K. Saravanan 38, J. Jaisimha 106, M. Abhinav 73, B. Anirudh 41 n.o., Arjun S. Nair 79 n.o.).

Group-B: At PBEL: Indian Bank 273 in 67.2 overs (Mitchell Anthony Mannayay 105, J. Rejin 3/65) lost to UFCC (T. Nagar) 274/3 in 71.4 overs (S. Srivatsan 68, V. Mithun Vijay 113, R. Rohit 50 n.o.).

At Sri Venkateswara: Swaraj 171 in 56 overs (R. Anirudh Seshadri 53, S. Ankith 3/59) lost to Crombest 175/4 in 37 overs (V.K. Vineeth 103 n.o., R. Sathyannarayan 43).

At A.M. Jain: Bunts 300 in 89.2 overs (N. Aakaash Sharma 87, M. Thamarai Selvan 53, Hunny 53, Charan Chunduru 48, P.S. Manikandan 4/63, V. Sanjeev Kumar 3/51) bt Komaleeswarar 277 in 73.2 overs (V. Abishek 76, P. Elaya Raja 37 n.o., B. Sivaramkrishnan 3/65).

A career engineered to perfection

Two Olympic gold medals, as many World titles and sustained dominance defined Axelsen's reign; the Dane's appetite for success shifted badminton's power centre outside Asia; he leaves behind a lasting legacy with one of the most fantastic records the sport has seen



GETTY IMAGES

Devvanshi Bihani

Athletes rarely leave with everything settled. There is usually something unfinished, perhaps a title missed, a conflict unresolved, or the lingering question of whether one more year might have changed the ending.

Viktor Axelsen does not seem to carry that with him. Forced to step away at 32 due to persistent back injuries that made training at the highest level unsustainable, the Dane's exit, announced on April 15, comes not with unfinished business, but with a sense of completion.

"I have accomplished everything I once dreamed of, and more. I've had the privilege of standing on the biggest stages, playing and winning the matches every player dreams of," Axelsen wrote in his retirement post.

Two Olympic gold medals and a bronze, two World championship titles, multiple European crowns, two All England trophies, the only player to complete a career Super 1000 slam, and a stretch between 2020 and 2023 where he reached 11 of 12 Super 1000 finals, winning 10 of them. Axelsen leaves behind a lasting legacy with one of the most fantastic records the sport has seen.

The making of a control freak

His career can look inevitable in hindsight – tall, powerful, technically precise, stepping into a post-Lin Dan era and taking over. But inevitability was something he engineered and not inherited.

If there is one thread that runs through his journey, it is control. Control over preparation. Over recovery. Over environment. Gill Clark, the voice of badminton, described him as someone who left "no stone unturned" in pursuit of improvement. But even that feels like an understatement. Axelsen didn't just turn over stones but redesigned the ground he was standing on.

He moved to Dubai to manage allergies and travel fatigue. He hired specialists outside badminton. A gymnastics coach for movement and a former marine for mental conditioning. He micromanaged nutrition, sleep, and training cycles. When he tested positive for COVID months before the Tokyo Olympics, he paid for a private air ambulance just to control how he recovered.

"To many people, I was sometimes 'extreme', but I always feared I would look back and feel like I could have done more. Living this way comes with a price, but this price is something I have been willing to pay in order to reach my fullest potential," he wrote. That instinct for control did not remain confined to how he trained. It shaped how he played and positioned himself within the sport.

Breaking the stranglehold

Badminton's power structure has rarely shifted far from Asia.

Training methods, tactical evolution, even informal knowledge-sharing flowed largely through China, Indonesia, Malaysia and, later, Japan and India. European players could break through, but they were still, in many ways,

operating from the outside.

Axelsen didn't accept that distance. Early in his career, he began learning Mandarin. Initially, he said, "the biggest thing for me has been to be able to speak with a lot of different players, especially the Chinese players, and know how they do stuff." He added, "That makes you think what you do is right. You can learn something from the Chinese players."

It occasionally offered unexpected advantages. During a match in 2014, a Chinese coach shouted "play faster", assuming Axelsen wouldn't understand. He did, and responded by slowing the game down. When he was at his peak, an apparent limitation could be turned into an advantage.

At 6'4", he altered the geometry of the court with steeper angles, longer reach, the ability to take the shuttle earlier and higher than most. Tall players were not new to the sport. Chen Long had won an Olympic gold with a 6'2" frame, and Denmark's Jan O. Jorgensen, similarly built, had reached the top tier.

But in badminton, height has traditionally come with trade-offs. Taller players often struggle with low defensive positions, quick changes of direction, and the constant forward recovery the sport demands. Chen showed what could be done through control and endurance, building his game around retrieval and rally tolerance.

Axelsen pushed in a different direction. He reworked his movements to suit his frame by lowering his base, sharpening his first step, and improving recovery so he could handle longer exchanges when needed. But he didn't build his game around endurance. Instead, he used that foundation to attack earlier, taking the shuttle higher and sooner to create sharper angles and shorten rallies.

That physical template is already being inherited. India's Ayush Shetty, also 6'4", emerged as the runner-up at the Badminton Asia Championships in the very week Axelsen announced his retirement.

The Dane had remarked that Ayush "reminds me of my younger self." A year earlier, in 2025, the Indian had spent time training with the legend.

"Axelsen is really strong and he has a great defence. I think it is really surprising that he can do all those things with that height...I have to be like that if I want to play at my very best," Ayush had said. He studied a version of the game that had already solved many of the problems height once posed.

The player others had to solve

In the years after Lin and Lee Chong Wei faded, Axelsen, for nearly a decade, remained the reference point in men's

singles, the player others had to solve.

He arrived during the 'GOAT' era when the old order was still standing. In Rio in 2016, he lost the semifinal to Chen before beating Lin for bronze, a result that felt less like an upset and more like an announcement by the then 22 year old. A year later, he defeated Lin in the 2017 World championship final.

Even during his most dominant phase – when he was winning the Olympic gold in Tokyo against Chen, defending it in Paris against Kunlavut Vitidsarn, and sweeping through Super 1000 events while beating the likes of Chou Tien Chen and Anders Antonsen in finals – there were brief windows when opponents managed to drag him away from his preferred rhythm.

India's HS Prannoy, for instance, dismantled him at the 2023 World championships in a match that exposed how even Axelsen's power could be blunted by tactical discipline. Lakshya Sen had done it earlier, outmanoeuvring him with speed and variation. Lee Zii Jia beat him in the 2021 All England final by matching him in attack. Antonsen, from Denmark's own system, pushed him in matches where there were no secrets left to uncover.

And then there was the rivalry that never fully played out.

Kento Momota, at his peak, was perhaps the closest thing to a stylistic counter. A player who could stretch rallies, absorb pressure, and force Axelsen into longer, more patient exchanges. For a stretch between 2018 and 2020, Momota built a commanding 14-3 head-to-head lead over the Dane. For a brief period before Momota's career-altering accident, their meetings hinted at a rivalry. If it had played out over time, it could have taken on the

shape badminton knows well: Axelsen as the Wei figure to Momota's Lin.

That absence does not diminish what Axelsen achieved – two Olympic titles and a 183-week reign as the world No. 1 (the third-longest in history) demand far more than circumstance. But it did leave behind one of badminton's lingering hypotheticals: how different the balance of power might have looked had both operated at full capacity over time.

Pushing against the system

For someone so obsessed with control, it was perhaps inevitable that Axelsen would eventually run into the limits of it.

He could control how he trained, where he lived, what he ate, how he recovered. He could redesign his game, his schedule, even his environment. But the structure of the sport, the calendar, the rules, the federation system, sat outside that control.

And Axelsen was not built to accept things he believed could have been done better. His public criticism of the Badminton World Federation was less a break in character than an extension of it.

He spoke about autonomy in a sport structured around federations. In a post in December 2024, he wrote that he was "so tired of the disconnect between players and BWF," arguing that a system where "everything needs to go through the Federation" left little room for athletes to make their own decisions.

He spoke about players being reluctant to raise concerns publicly, given the power federations hold, but he was keen on his own responsibility "for current players and future generations."

He also voiced about recovery in a calendar that rewards constant participation and about mental strain in a system that still struggles to account for it. He pointed to cases like that of Beiwen Zhang to highlight how mental health struggles were often insufficient grounds to step away, asking: "If we as a sport don't take mental health seriously, then where are we heading?"

He joined Malaysians in criticising Badminton Association of Malaysia for the "drastic and unjustified" two-year-ban imposed on Jia.

The former world No. 1 did so while being one of the system's biggest beneficiaries – filling arenas, anchoring broadcasts, and winning consistently – and yet one of those most visibly strained by its demands, at times sharing medical scans publicly to explain withdrawals. There was a directness to it that felt familiar. On court, Axelsen carried himself in much the same way: upright, deliberate, unmistakable. The headband, the clenched fist, the controlled aggression in his movement; a presence that filled space and demanded response – from opponents in rallies and from arenas that filled for him.

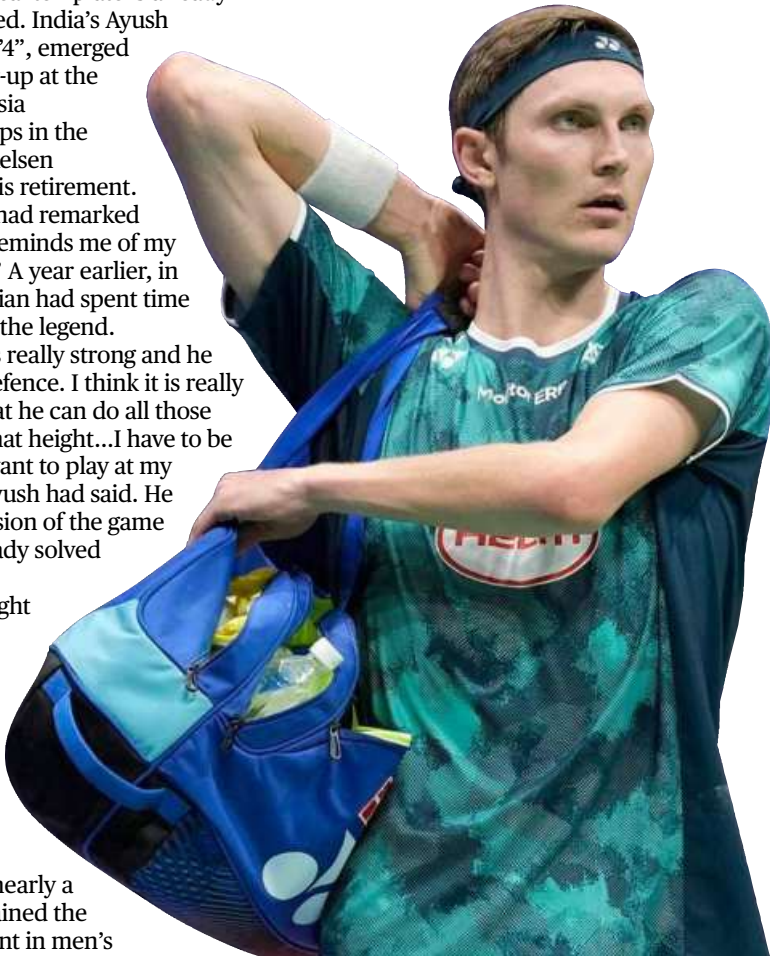
Off it, that same clarity showed in how he spoke, not always diplomatic, rarely ambiguous, and grounded in a sense of responsibility. The Dane leaves with titles, records, and dominance. And with the rare assurance that, in a career defined by control, there was nothing left he chose not to fight for. "I don't regret anything one bit," he wrote.

THE GIST

▼ Clark, the voice of badminton, described Axelsen as someone who left "no stone unturned" in pursuit of improvement

▼ In the years after Lin and Wei faded, the Dane, for nearly a decade, remained the reference point in men's singles

▼ The 32-year-old did not shy away from publicly criticising things he believed could have been done better



Why science and scientists must learn to celebrate failures

Narratives that present scientific experiments as a smooth story of success are counter-effective; to ensure science remains dynamic, innovative, and honest, it is necessary to foster a culture of appreciating and learning from failure rather than hiding it

Biju Dharmapalan

Failure is part and parcel of research but many scientists consider discussing it in a scientific forum to be taboo. Laboratories are littered with unfinished experiments and inconclusive facts and theories that failed to stand the test of study. However, when science is being communicated – whether to funding bodies, professional journals, or audiences – it comes across as a smooth story of success. Just narratives are counter-effective. To ensure science is dynamic, innovative, and honest, we have to foster a culture of appreciating and learning from failure rather than hiding it. In its essence, science progresses by trial and error. A scientist postulates hypotheses while anticipating that many of them will be discarded. Every unsuccessful experiment sharpens the edges of knowledge and guides further investigation. However, systems of science such as funding, publication, and career progression are skewed towards successes alone. Grants are generally awarded on the basis of promising results and a large volume of papers, and in favour of those with positive results. Unsuccessful or negative outcomes are often overlooked, leading to a biased ecosystem in which only success is allowed to be seen.

Not to be stigmatised
In the early 1980s, Australian scientists Barry Marshall and Robin Warren claimed that a bacterium called *Helicobacter pylori* caused peptic ulcers. Papers on the idea were however rejected by journals and dismissed by the gastroenterological establishment; the latter had long held that the stomach was too acidic for microbes. (Of course, there was also reasoned scepticism in pockets of the research community, which did not think that the duo had provided sufficient evidence for their hypothesis.) They were unable to get their findings published and were also not taken seriously, but they had reasons to believe they were right. Then, in 1984, Mr. Marshall famously drank a broth containing *H. pylori* bacteria, expecting he would develop ulcers in around a year and thus prove to the research community that their idea had merit. Rather than a year, he developed symptoms of gastritis within a few days. The duo won a Nobel Prize in 2005 for their work on identifying *H. pylori* as a cause of gastritis and peptic ulcers. It was a testament to how publication bias allowed a treatable condition to go untreated for years because the system had no process or culture to deal with what it perceived to be a failure. To really embrace failure, science may need to draw inspiration from domains



Knowledge gambit: Science progresses by trial and error and every unsuccessful experiment guides further investigation. SASUN BUGHDARYAN/UNSPLASH

beyond academia. The technology sector, particularly in entrepreneurial ecosystems, has long embraced a “fail fast, fail often” philosophy. Here, failure is not to be stigmatised but treated as a stepping stone, an essential part of iterative learning.

Psychological aspect
While academic science cannot replicate this model entirely, given its different stakes and responsibilities, it can certainly adopt its underlying mindset: that failure is informative rather than shameful. Another valuable analogy is in sports. Athletes incorporate replays and coaching sessions to analyse their failures and convert them into learning opportunities. However, failures in science do not tend to include well-orchestrated reflection. Some changes are commendable. New publication formats like ‘registered reports’ – where scientists commit to publishing the results of an experiment even before they begin it, whether they are positive or negative – are shifting the focus from results to research design and thus to methodological rigour. Nonetheless, these efforts are still spreading their wings. The major transformation the enterprise as a whole requires in mainstream practice is pending. There is always the possibility that experiments do not pay off without a clear explanation, and researchers internalise failure as personal rather than as a natural occurrence in the process of intricate enquiry. This psychological

There is always the possibility that experiments do not pay off without a clear explanation, and researchers internalise failure as personal rather than as a natural occurrence

aspect is especially important to novice researchers. In a highly competitive environment where not everyone feels safe at work, the fear of failure may lower the incentive to take risks. This makes researchers more inclined towards safer, incremental projects rather than risky, innovative ideas. Such a fear of risk can eventually impede the pace of scientific development.

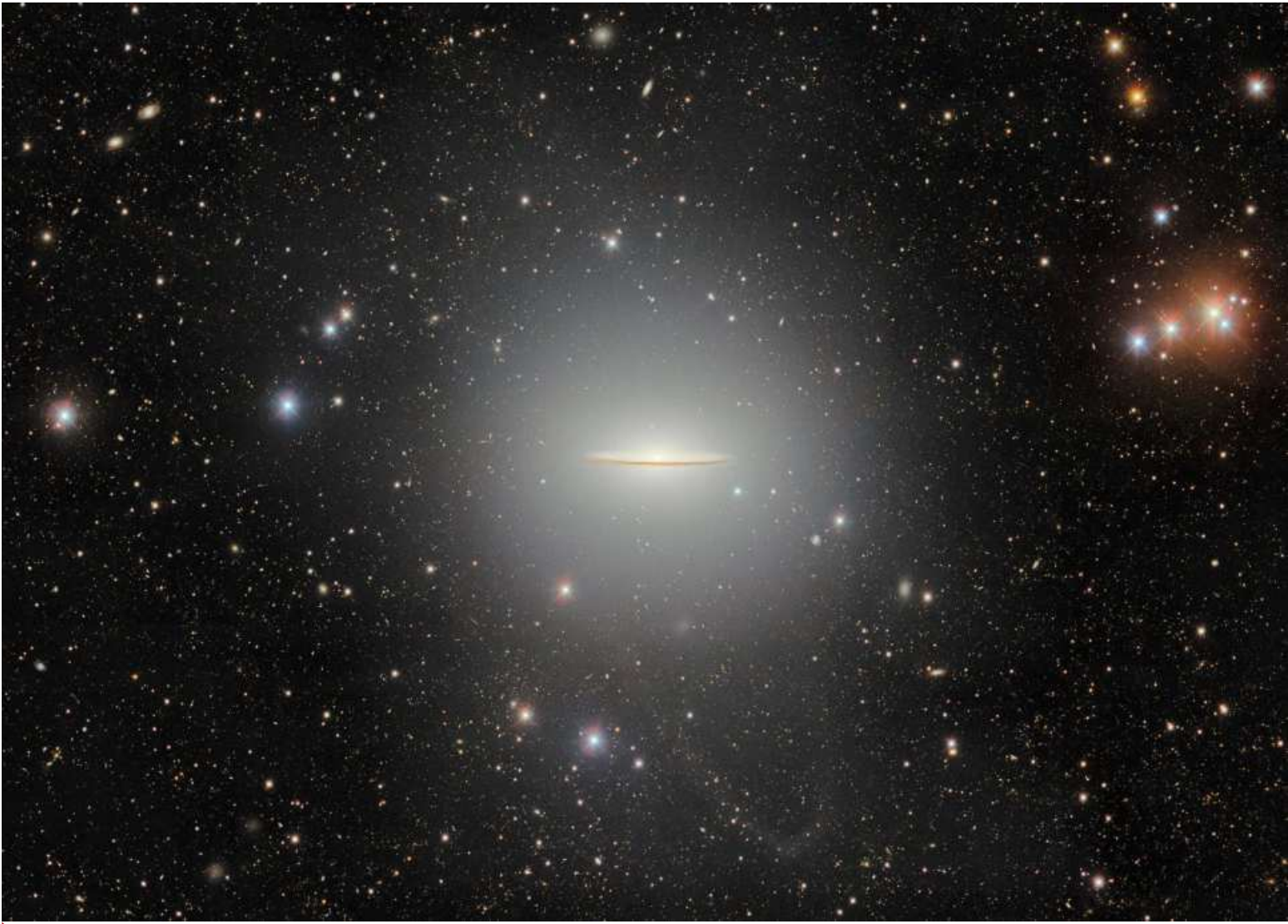
Communicating science
A culture change is thus much needed. Younger scientists would like to see their senior counterparts and principal investigators set good examples by talking openly about their failures and uncertainties. Mentorship should also not be limited to success: it should also openly deal with setbacks. People can become more resilient and honest in their intellectual practices by acknowledging that doubt and failure are parts of science. Funding bodies and institutions can also play a role. The criteria of evaluation need to shift from the success of specific research outcomes to the quality of the

research questions, research methods, and the lessons learnt. Grant proposals and academic CVs can include sections that document and articulate failures as part of the research experience. Establishing platforms to share negative findings and failed experiments could also contribute to a richer scientific ledger. Through open science projects and online archives, novel possibilities are available to share such knowledge, minimise repetition, and foster collaboration. Notably, the public communication of science needs to change as well. The representation of science as a succession of discoveries creates unrealistic expectations and diminishes confidence in the face of failure. Scientists can raise a more informed and appreciative population by showing that science is a messy, iterative, and sometimes uncertain process. This is necessary, especially in the case of developing drugs or going to space, where errors are bound to happen, and it could be the most important lesson to go through. Science in practice is a long journey characterised by perseverance, failure, and slow success. Science should not conceal these features but accept them. That is when every failure can serve as a stepping-stone to significant and hopefully sustainable breakthroughs.

(Biju Dharmapalan is Dean (Academic Affairs), Garden City University and an adjunct faculty member at the National Institute of Advanced Studies, Bengaluru. bijudharmapalan@gmail.com)

THE GIST
▼ Science in practice is a long journey characterised by perseverance, failure, and slow success
▼ In a highly competitive environment where not everyone feels safe at work, the fear of failure may lower the incentive to take risks which can eventually impede the pace of scientific development
▼ A culture change is thus much needed where mentorship is not limited to success with criteria of evaluation focused on quality of the research

BIG SHOT



The Sombrero galaxy is a popular target for amateur observing and astronomical research. Its recognisable extended halo and dust-filled disk are captured in this image from the Dark Energy Camera mounted on the Víctor M. Blanco Telescope in Chile. CTIO/NOIRLAB/DOE/NSF/AURA.

WHAT IS IT?
A face of Pompeii

Reuters
Archaeologists in Italy’s Pompeii have for the first time used artificial intelligence (AI) to reconstruct the appearance of one of the victims of the volcanic eruption that destroyed the ancient Roman city nearly 2,000 years ago. The AI-generated image, released by the Pompeii Archaeological Park on Monday, shows a man ducking for cover while holding a large bowl over his head, with a flaming Mt Vesuvius in the background. It is based on the recent discovery of the remains of a male adult, just outside one of the southern gates of the city, which were lying next to a terracotta mortar that he presumably used as protection. Archaeologists believe the man was killed by a shower of volcanic rocks, in the early hours of the second day of the eruption, while trying to escape towards the sea. He was also carrying a lamp and 10 bronze coins, the park said. “If used well, AI can contribute to a renewal of classical studies, illustrating the classical world in a more immersive way,” the head of the archaeological park, Gabriel Zuchtriegel, said in a statement. The once-thriving city of Pompeii, about 25 km southeast of Naples, was buried in the eruption of Mt Vesuvius in AD 79, preserving buildings, objects and graffiti under metres of ash. Rediscovered in the 18th century, it is



A view of the Pompeii Archeological Park, near Naples, Italy, December 14, 2022. AP

now one of the world’s most significant archaeological sites, and one of the most popular tourist sites in Italy, with 4.3 million visitors in 2024, according to the latest statistics.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Science’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Accounts involved in digital arrest scams banned by WhatsApp

9400 The action was detailed by the Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre of the Ministry of Home Affairs. The DoT and the Telecom Service Providers have set a strict new timeline for neutralising fraudulent SIM cards, and aiming at a mechanism to block suspicious cards within 2-3 hours of identification, it said. PTI

Expected reduction in carbon emissions by Indore solar plant

1.46 in lakh tonnes. The Indore Municipal Corporation's solar power plant is expected to reduce carbon dioxide emissions by approximately 1.46 lakh tons annually through its 60 MW renewable energy unit. A bulk of ₹308 crore cost of the plant, spread over 211 acres in Khargone district, was raised through a public issue of green bonds. PTI

Investment in the new Google data centre near Visakhapatnam

1.35 in ₹ crores. Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday laid the foundation for a \$15 billion Google Artificial Intelligence data centre near Visakhapatnam. Mr. Naidu said this project was started in September 2025. According to the CM, the Google data centre will generate "thousands of jobs" for the youth of the State. PTI

Foreigners held in Uganda in crackdown on illegal migration

231 Ugandan authorities said Tuesday that they have detained dozens of foreigners in a crackdown on illegal migration, that the Internal Affairs Ministry suggested was linked to human traffickers and cyberscam operations. Authorities say they acted on intelligence showing large groups of foreigners living or working in Uganda without necessary documents. PTI

Electors cleared by tribunals to vote in phase 2 of Bengal polls

1,468 A total of 1,468 people, who have been added to the West Bengal electoral rolls following the SIR-linked tribunal orders, will be able to exercise their franchise in the second phase of the Assembly polls on April 29, an EC official said on Tuesday. The second phase will cover 142 constituencies PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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On TCS harassment and conversion case

Concerns have been raised about the Tata Consultancy Services sexual exploitation and alleged forcible conversions case that involves nine FIRs, related to complaints of alleged sexual exploitation, rape and forcible conversion at the company's office in Nashik, Maharashtra, between 2022 and 2026.

EXPLAINER

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit

The story so far:

Last month, Nashik Police claimed that they had busted a racket of alleged forced conversions and sexual exploitation at a multi-national company's office in the city. Nine FIRs were registered and eight persons were arrested. Police said they were looking for one more accused, who they claimed is on the run. A Nashik court has heard her anticipatory bail plea and will give an order on May 2. TCS has ordered an internal probe, suspending all the persons named in the FIRs, adding that no formal complaint has been registered with it yet.

Overview of the sexual harassment and forcible conversions case

The TCS case involves nine FIRs. They are related to complaints of alleged sexual exploitation, rape and forcible conversion at Tata Consultancy Services in Nashik, Maharashtra, between 2022 and 2026.

Timeline of the complaints

On March 26, 2026, the first FIR was registered at Deolali Camp Police station. It was filed by a 23-year-old woman employee of TCS, claiming that since 2022, an accused had tried to convince her into a relationship with him. She said that the accused had asked her to apply to TCS, where he was already working. She claimed that after she got selected, she was allegedly forced into physical relations by the accused, on the pretext of marriage. She further alleged that another co-accused, on learning of their relations, also sought physical favours from her.

She has claimed that three accused – Danish Sheikh, Tausif Akhtar and Nida Khan, used to allegedly speak ill about Hinduism, trying to dissuade her from following Hinduism. She claimed that she learnt in February 2026, that the main accused was already married with two



GETTY IMAGES

children. She further alleged that the three accused hurt her religious sentiments, that Danish Sheikh kept physical relations with her on the promise of marriage, and that Tausif Akhtar sexually harassed her multiple times.

Police have claimed that the three accused taught her Islamic practices, and convinced her to follow them. The original FIR accessed by *The Hindu* does not mention it, and supplementary statements, if any, could not be accessed.

After the first FIR was registered, till April 3, 2026, eight more FIRs were registered in quick succession, at Mumbai Naka Police station. While seven FIRs were registered by women, one was filed by a man who alleged that he was forced to convert, Nashik Police said. The complainant claimed that he was allegedly forced to eat beef, offer namaz and recite *kalma*. He has told the police that the efforts allegedly started in 2023-24. When the victim's father suffered from paralysis, the accused allegedly said he would only recover if the victim accepted Islam, he told the police.

The other cases pertain to rape, obscene comments, insult of modesty, and hurting religious sentiments by

children. She further alleged that the three accused hurt her religious sentiments, that Danish Sheikh kept physical relations with her on the promise of marriage, and that Tausif Akhtar sexually harassed her multiple times.

Steps taken by the police

Nashik Police have formed a 12-member Special Investigation Team led by an Assistant Police Commissioner to investigate the matter. Several stringent sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, have been invoked for sexual intercourse through deceitful means, sexual harassment, stalking, insulting the modesty of a woman, abetment, criminal defamation, intentional or malicious acts to outrage religion, intentionally wounding religious sentiments, common intent, etc. The sections include Sections 69, 75, 78, 79, 49, 356, 302, 299, 3(5) of BNS. In the first FIR, Sections 3(1)(w)(i), 3(1)(w)(ii), 3(2)(v)

and 3(1)(s) of the SC, ST Prevention of Atrocities Act, 1989, have been invoked.

According to the police, they were alerted by a local social-political activist after the parents of the first complainant allegedly expressed apprehensions about her changed behaviour pattern. The police thereafter conducted a covert operation in the concerned TCS office, where police teams went disguised as housekeeping staff to gather intelligence. The FIRs were registered after the police spoke with several complainants and asked them to register formal complaints. A woman officer played a key role in gathering information from women survivors of alleged sexual harassment, police said.

Concerns raised in the issue

Civil rights activists have raised concerns about the process, narrative, and impartiality of the probe. They have claimed that cases of sexual harassment are allegedly being portrayed as 'corporate jihaad' or 'love jihaad'. They have sought an impartial probe into the alleged sexual harassment faced by the women, and about the structural lapses in addressing them. They have also raised concerns about an alleged 'media trial', where a woman accused was allegedly termed an HR professional. TCS later clarified that she was neither an HR manager nor responsible for recruitment, but that she was employed as a process associate without any leadership responsibilities. Civil rights groups have raised concerns about the lack of evidence for any externally funded religious conversion network or organised conspiracy.

Arguments by the defence

The lawyers of the accused have primarily argued on two issues: There is no law against conversions in Maharashtra. They have questioned the legal basis for booking the accused for alleged forcible conversions. They also contend that acts of voluntary choice are being incriminated.

THE GIST

Nashik Police have formed a Special Investigation Team to probe the sexual harassment and forcible conversions case. Several sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, have been invoked.

Civil rights activists have questioned the process, narrative and impartiality of the probe, calling for an independent inquiry into the alleged harassment faced by the women, and the structural lapses in addressing it.

The tragedy of recurring Rohingya refugee deaths

The capsizing of a fishing trawler carrying refugees draws attention to the cost of protracted displacement

Saeed Pande

Story so far:

A fishing trawler carrying around 250-280 people, including Rohingya refugees and Bangladeshi nationals, capsized in the Andaman Sea in mid-April 2026 while attempting to reach Malaysia. According to UNHCR - the UN Refugee Agency and the International Organization for Migration (IOM), around 250 people are feared dead or missing, based on preliminary estimates. The vessel departed from Teknaf in Cox's Bazar, Bangladesh, and was reportedly overcrowded and overwhelmed by rough seas.

Only around 9-10 survivors were rescued. Survivors reported that the boat travelled for about four days before capsizing, with some people floating for over 36 hours before being rescued by passing vessels.

Life-threatening sea journeys

Since the 2017 Rohingya crisis in Rakhine State, over 7,00,000 Rohingya have fled to Cox's Bazar, in Bangladesh. Myanmar's 1982 Citizenship Law rendered them effectively stateless, denying basic rights. In Bangladesh, more than one million refugees live in congested camps with limited or no access to education and formal work. According to the UNHCR, funding cuts since 2023 have sharply reduced food rations. Smuggling networks exploit this vulnerability, charging high fees for passage to Malaysia, where informal labour opportunities and diaspora links exist.

The 1,500-nautical-mile Bangladesh-Malaysia route relies on unseaworthy boats, often carrying over 200 people with minimal supplies, for a journey that could take 5-7 days. Reports by humanitarian agencies indicate that vessels are sometimes denied disembarkation or allegedly pushed back,

leaving migrants stranded at sea.

According to a UNHCR report released on April 17 this year, 2025 was the deadliest year on record for Rohingya sea crossings, with nearly 900 dead or missing. The report observes that 6,500 attempted the journey, with about one in seven perishing. The trend has continued into 2026, with over 2,800 departures recorded between January and mid-April.

A comparison with the Mediterranean Sea highlights both parallels and contrasts. The IOM estimates nearly 28,000 deaths there since 2014, as migrants fled conflicts in Syria, Eritrea, and Afghanistan.

Europe's response, though contested, is relatively structured. Following the 2013 Lampedusa shipwreck, Italy launched Operation Mare Nostrum, rescuing around 1,50,000 people. It was followed by EU-led missions such as Operation Sophia, beginning in 2015, which targeted smuggling networks while also supporting

rescue efforts. The Frontex coordinates joint operations, while the Common European Asylum System sets standards for asylum processing.

Legal accountability also plays a role. In *Hirsi Jamaa v. Italy* (2012), the European Court of Human Rights ruled that pushbacks violated international law. NGOs such as Médecins Sans Frontières and SOS Méditerranée have also rescued thousands. In contrast, Southeast Asia lacks binding frameworks. During the 2015 Andaman crisis, thousands were stranded at sea amid delayed responses. Without legal obligations or coordination, responses remain ad hoc.

The governance vacuum

The Rohingya maritime crisis exposes a governance vacuum in South and Southeast Asia. Conflict has strengthened the Arakan Army (a local Buddhist armed group), which by 2024 controlled large parts of Myanmar's Rakhine State, driving displacement in the region. Countries such as India, Bangladesh, Thailand, and Malaysia are not signatories to the 1951 Refugee Convention, limiting formal protections. The ASEAN's 2021 Five-Point Consensus has been constrained by the non-interference principle and internal divisions between Indonesia and Malaysia versus Thailand and Myanmar, reinforcing policy paralysis. (Saeed Pande is a freelance writer with a focus on current affairs and geopolitics.)

THE GIST

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